

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Acts

Acts 1:1–3

Here, Luke summarizes his first book, the Gospel of Luke, which he wrote for Theophilus. Luke also calls him “most excellent” ([Luke 1:3](#)). This title indicates that he was a person of very important social status (compare [Acts 23:26](#); [24:2](#); [26:25](#)). He was probably a financial donor or patron who helped Luke with the costs of publishing or distributing his work (see study note on Luke 1:3).

Acts 1:3

- *He presented Himself to them with many convincing proofs that He was alive:* The Gospels provide evidence for Christ’s resurrection:
- Jesus’s tomb was empty ([Luke 24:3–4](#)).
- No one disturbed his grave clothes ([John 20:3–9](#)).
- Many people saw him (see [Matthew 28](#); [Mark 16:1–8](#); [Luke 24:1–53](#); [John 20:11–21:23](#); [1 Corinthians 15:3–8](#)).
- Jesus appeared to the apostles to help them overcome their doubt ([Matthew 28:17](#); [Luke 24:17–24](#), 38, 41; [John 20:27](#); see [Mark 16:14](#)).
- *the kingdom of God:* This was the main theme of Jesus’s teaching (see [Acts 1:6–8](#); [Matthew 4:17](#); [Mark 1:14–15](#); [Luke 4:43](#)).

Acts 1:4

wait for the gift the Father promised: See [2:1–13](#); compare with [John 14:15–17](#).

Acts 1:5

baptized: See “Baptism” Theme Note.

Acts 1:6–11

He was taken up: Jesus ascended into heaven (see also [Luke 24:50–53](#)). This happened on the Mount of Olives ([Acts 1:12](#); [Luke 24:50](#)). This was the last physical appearance of Jesus. He ascended into heaven, where he will stay “until the time comes for the restoration of all things” ([Acts 3:21](#)).

Acts 1:8

- This key verse shows how the good news about Jesus extended from place to place:
- It began in Jerusalem and Judea ([1:6–8:1](#)).
- It then came to Samaria ([8:4–25](#)).

- Next, it went to Antioch in Syria ([11:19–30](#)).
- Later, it extended across the Mediterranean Sea to Rome ([13:1–28:31](#)).
- Christ gave a similar mission to Saul of Tarsus ([9:15](#)). At first, Saul was well-known for persecuting Jewish Christians. After his encounter with Christ, he became the main person spreading the gospel to non-Jews (Gentiles).
- *when the Holy Spirit comes:* The Holy Spirit provided the power for all these missionary efforts for the good news about Jesus.

Acts 1:10

as He was going: The ascension of Jesus into heaven shows his promotion to a position of ultimate authority (see [Ephesians 1:19–23](#); [Philippians 2:9–11](#)).

Acts 1:11

in the same way: Jesus promised to return from heaven in the same way (see [Matthew 24:30](#); [Mark 13:26](#); [John 14:3](#)). Jesus has gone to heaven to prepare a place for his followers ([John 12:26](#); [14:1–4](#); [2 Corinthians 5:4](#); [Philippians 3:21](#); [Hebrews 6:20](#)).

Acts 1:12

Those who witnessed Christ going into heaven returned to Jerusalem with joy, worship, excitement, and praise to God ([Luke 24:52](#)). The angels’ message eased their doubts (see study note on Acts 1:3).

Acts 1:13

All eleven of the remaining apostles were present (compare [Matthew 10:2–4](#); [Mark 3:16–19](#); [Luke 6:13–16](#)). Judas Iscariot is not on this list because he had already betrayed Jesus and killed himself ([Acts 1:18–19](#)).

Acts 1:13–26

The apostles waited for the promised gift of the Holy Spirit ([1:4–5](#)). All 120 disciples in Jerusalem were persisting in prayer ([1:13–14](#)). Then they chose a new apostle to replace Judas Iscariot ([1:15–26](#)).

Acts 1:14

- The first disciples came together for worship, fellowship, and prayer (see also [2:42](#), [46–47](#); [4:24–31](#); [5:12](#); [12:5](#); [13:1–3](#)). The faithful women who witnessed Jesus’s crucifixion and resurrection were there ([Luke 23:49](#), [54–56](#); [24:1–10](#), [22](#)).
- The brothers of Jesus did not believe in him during his earthly ministry ([John 7:3–5](#); compare

[Matthew 12:46–49](#)). But they became his disciples after his resurrection.

Acts 1:16–17

the Scripture had to be fulfilled: See [1:20](#).

Acts 1:18–19

The account in the Gospel of Matthew is slightly different ([Matthew 27:3–10](#)). We can match the two accounts by understanding the priests' purchase of the "Field of Blood" as if they acted on behalf of Judas. Also, Judas may have killed himself by hanging, but he later fell headfirst. Then his body split open, possibly when the rope broke.

Acts 1:20–21

May another take his position: It was extremely important to find someone to replace Judas so there would still be twelve apostles. The church was the new Israel so it needed twelve leaders chosen and appointed by God (see [Matthew 19:28](#); [Luke 22:29–30](#)).

Acts 1:21–22

To qualify to be an apostle, a man needed to have been with the other apostles throughout the public ministry of Jesus. This period started from the time John baptized Jesus and continued until Jesus was taken up into heaven.

Acts 1:23–26

- With prayer and humble dependence on God that he would reveal his will, the apostles cast lots ([1:14](#), [24](#)). This was a traditional way to discover God's will (see [Leviticus 16:8](#); [Numbers 27:21](#); [Deuteronomy 33:8](#); [Joshua 14:2](#); [18:3–10](#); [Proverbs 16:33](#)). God chose Matthias by lot to replace Judas. After Pentecost, the Holy Spirit guided the followers of Jesus through dreams, visions, and prophecies instead of through lots (compare [Acts 2:17–18](#); [13:2](#); [16:7–10](#)).
- *You know everyone's heart:* See also [1 Samuel 16:6–7](#); [1 Kings 8:39](#); [1 Chronicles 28:9](#); [2 Chronicles 6:30](#); [Psalms 7:9](#); [44:21](#); [Jeremiah 11:20](#); [John 2:24–25](#); [Revelation 2:23](#).

Acts 2:1–4

Jews observed three traditional annual festivals. Many people traveled to the temple in Jerusalem for these feasts (see [Leviticus 23:1–44](#)):

- The Feast of Unleavened Bread (which includes Passover)
- The Feast of Weeks (also called Pentecost or the Feast of Harvest)
- The Feast of Tabernacles

On Pentecost, Jewish people gathered in Jerusalem to thank God for the harvest and his blessings. At the same time, the disciples of Jesus gathered together in prayer with shared hope. Then the Holy Spirit came and filled the believers who were present.

Acts 2:4

- *And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit:* This event marks when the Holy Spirit came down from heaven. He filled the disciples, as Jesus had promised, to empower them as witnesses of Christ's resurrection ([1:4–5](#), [8](#)). The Spirit's wisdom, energy, and power enabled the church's work and witness (for example, [2:14–41](#), [43](#); [4:31](#); [9:17](#), [20](#); [13:9–12](#); see also [Ephesians 5:18](#)).
- *began to speak in other tongues:* The Holy Spirit gave them the ability to communicate so people from other countries could hear about God's works in their own languages ([Acts 2:6–11](#)). This passage is one of several references to speaking in "other tongues" (see also [10:44–48](#); [19:6](#); [1 Corinthians 14:2–28](#), [39](#)). This divine gift shows the energy of the presence of God's Spirit. This event marks the beginning of the gospel (the good news about Jesus) being announced to people from every nation.

Acts 2:5–11

Since Pentecost was a feast people had to travel to attend, Jews from every nation were in Jerusalem (see study note on [2:1–4](#)). They could hear the gospel (the good news about Jesus) in their own languages. The gospel is for all people ([2:38–39](#)).

Acts 2:9–11

- The Parthians came from the region between the Tigris River and India.

The Medes, now known as Kurds, were from Media, located east of Mesopotamia and north of the Persian Gulf.

The Elamites were from Elam. This area is now in Iran, north of the Persian Gulf and just east of the Tigris River.

Mesopotamia was between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. Judea was well known as the Jewish homeland.

Cappadocia, Pontus, and Asia were Roman provinces in Asia Minor, now part of Turkey (see [1 Peter 1:1](#)). The apostle Paul later taught and preached in some of these areas (see [Acts 16:6](#); [19:10](#), [26](#)).

Phrygia and Pamphylia were districts in Asia Minor that Paul later visited ([13:13](#); [18:23](#)).

Egypt had a large Jewish population, especially in Alexandria (see [18:24](#)).

North Africa included Libya and Cyrene.

Rome was the capital of the Roman Empire and home to thousands of Jews.

The Cretans were from the island of Crete, located south-

southeast of Greece.

The Arabs were from the area south and east of Jerusalem.

- Including all of these nations demonstrates how God intended the gospel to reach the ends of the earth (1:8).

Acts 2:10–11

converts to Judaism: See study note on 13:43.

Acts 2:14–36

This is the first of about 30 speeches in Acts and one of the most important. It marks the beginning of the Christian church. It is a typical example of the preaching of the apostles.

The apostles proclaimed:

1. that the Old Testament promises came true in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus, the promised Messiah;
2. that the apostles were eyewitnesses of the public ministry of Jesus and were his chosen representatives;
3. that people must turn away (repent) from their sins and trust in God through Christ; and
4. that salvation and the presence of the Holy Spirit are promised to those who have a positive response to this message of the gospel.

This basic message repeats in the sermons of chapters 3, 4, 5, 8, 10, and 13. The same themes characterized the apostle Paul's preaching (see 1 Corinthians 15:3–9). The apostles all repeated this message when preaching to both Jews and non-Jews (Gentiles) throughout the world around the Mediterranean Sea. All people must turn away (repent) from their sins and turn to God by trusting in Jesus Christ.

Acts 2:17–21

This passage quotes Joel 2:28–32. The prophet Joel prophesied that in the last days, many people would have the gifts of prophecy, including visions and dreams. This would include both young and old, and both men and women (Joel 2:28–29). In Acts, on the day of Pentecost, Peter announced that Joel's prophecy was coming true, indicating that "the last days" had begun.

Acts 2:23–28

Although cruel men put Jesus to death on a cross, they did not defeat God's plan for salvation. In fact, God raised Jesus from the dead, just as David had foretold (2:25–28).

Acts 2:27

abandon my soul to Hades: See the study note on Matthew 11:23.

Acts 2:32–36

God has raised this Jesus to life, to which we are all witnesses: The theme of witnessing repeats often in Acts (for example, 3:15; 4:33; 5:32; 10:39–43). The main point of this message is that God the Father, as he promised, is now pouring out his Holy Spirit on the church through the resurrected Jesus. All the people of Israel were called to recognize that God had acted with power. He made Jesus, whom they put to death on a cross, both Lord and Messiah!

Acts 2:34–35

This passage quotes Psalm 110:1, which Jesus fulfilled when he ascended (went up) into heaven (Acts 1:9).

Acts 2:37–38

Brothers, what shall we do?: Peter urged his listeners to repent of their sins, trust in God, and be baptized. See the "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 2:42

- *fellowship:* The Greek word *koinōnia* means a close relationship marked by sharing and participating in life together.
- *and to prayer:* At this stage, prayer probably included taking part in the formal prayers of the temple (see 3:1).

Acts 2:42–47

Luke makes a clear connection between personal faith and belonging to the Christian community. Life in this new community included:

- devotion to the teaching of the apostles from God's word,
- fellowship,
- sharing,
- joy, and
- praise.

As a result, the Lord continued to add to their number those who were being saved.

Acts 3:1–11

Jesus promised that his disciples would do greater works than he did (John 14:12; see Mark 16:20). This promise came true through the signs, wonders, and mighty works of the apostles (Acts 2:43; 5:12; 8:4–8).

The apostle Peter showed the power to heal in the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth (3:6, 16). The healing was immediate and evident (3:8). It led the man to praise God (3:8–9; compare 2:47; 16:25; Luke 2:20; 17:15–18; 18:43; 19:37; 24:53). This event is the first of many displays of divine power given to the apostles in Acts (Acts 4:24–31; 5:12; 6:8; 8:6; 9:33–42; 28:8).

Acts 3:6

In the name of Jesus: Speaking the name of Jesus demonstrates who he is and his power to heal (see [Mark 9:38–39](#)).

Acts 3:10–11

- The Beautiful Gate was probably the Nicanor Gate, made of bronze from the city of Corinth. It was on the east side of the temple (see Josephus, *War* 5.5.3). It had rich decorations of silver and gold plates on its panels. The gold and silver were heavier and more valuable than the plates on other gates.
- Solomon's Colonnade was a covered place to walk on the east side of the temple (see Josephus, *War* 5.5.1–3; *Antiquities* 20.9.7).

Acts 3:12–26

The speeches in the book of Acts about telling others the good news focus on Jesus, who was put to death on a cross and raised to life. These speeches call people to repent and to place their faith in Jesus as the promised Messiah and the judge God has appointed (2:38; 3:19; 11:18; 17:30; 26:20). They also announce the same good news for the people of Israel and for Gentiles everywhere: there is “peace through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all” (10:36).

Acts 3:15

Many Jewish people could not imagine that God himself, the author of life, could be killed. They did not recognize Jesus as the Messiah (compare 13:27; [Luke 23:34](#)). They also did not understand that the Messiah would be divine, that is, sharing God's nature (see [John 1:1–18](#); compare [Daniel 7:13–14](#)).

Acts 3:17

- *brothers:* This was a common way to address each other (13:15, 26, 38; [Genesis 27:29](#); [Leviticus 10:6](#); 25:46; [Numbers 20:3](#); [Deuteronomy 1:28](#); 24:7; [Joshua 22:3–4](#); [2 Samuel 2:26](#); [Ezekiel 11:15](#)).
- *in ignorance:* See [Acts 17:30](#); [1 Timothy 1:12–14](#). The Christian message challenges this lack of knowledge. The gospel calls everyone to respond with faith and to repent ([Acts 2:38](#)).

Acts 3:19

Other sections of the book of Acts and the Gospel of Luke explain the good news of “forgiveness” in more detail (see [Acts 5:30–32](#); 10:36–43; 13:26–38; [Luke 24:25–27](#), 45–47).

Acts 3:19–21

The message of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) brings comfort (see [Matthew 11:28–29](#)). The second coming

of Jesus will bring *times of refreshing* from God. He will *send Jesus* to his people again.

Acts 3:22

Jesus fulfills the ancient promise that God would raise up a prophet like Moses (see [Deuteronomy 18:15](#), 18; compare [John 6:14](#); 7:40).

Acts 3:23

Refusing to obey Jesus, who is God's ultimate prophet, will lead to severe consequences ([John 3:16](#), 17, 36).

Acts 3:25

all the families of the earth will be blessed: God always intended the covenant people to share his blessings with the world, not for the Jews to be selfish and keep God's blessing only for themselves.

Acts 4:1

Sadducees: See “The Sadducees” Profile.

Acts 4:1–22

Throughout the Bible, God's people often experienced persecution. God's servants often encountered hostility and opposition ([Deuteronomy 30:7](#); [1 Kings 18:13](#); [Nehemiah 4:1–3](#); [Jeremiah 37–38](#); [Matthew 23:34–37](#); [Luke 11:49–51](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:14–15](#)). Jesus was also persecuted ([Luke 4:29](#); [John 5:16](#)). He warned his disciples to expect similar treatment ([Matthew 10:23](#); 24:9; [Mark 13:9](#); [Luke 21:12](#); [John 16:2](#)). However, he promised that the Holy Spirit would provide them with strength ([Acts 1:8](#); [Luke 12:11–12](#); 21:15).

The book of Acts records many examples of persecution ([Acts 4:3](#); 5:17–41; 7:54–8:3; 9:1–2; 11:19; 12:2; 13:50; 14:19; 16:19–24). But it also emphasizes that the Holy Spirit empowers apostles to testify in such situations (4:8–13; 6:10; 7:55). The courage of Peter and John before the hostile Jewish high council shows how Christians should face persecution with courage and power (4:20).

Acts 4:4

and the number of men grew to about five thousand: See study note on [Matthew 14:21](#).

Acts 4:13

they were unschooled, ordinary men: This means they were not scholars or trained teachers of the Scriptures. Peter and John were working men without higher education.

The members of the Jewish high council were educated, and people saw them as authorities on the Scriptures and

religious matters. Because of this, the council members were amazed to hear untrained men speak so boldly about these topics.

Acts 4:16–18

They acknowledged the miracle but still tried to prevent the message. Jesus had experienced similar resistance ([Matthew 19:8](#); [Mark 10:5](#); see also [Deuteronomy 10:16](#); [30:6](#); [Jeremiah 4:4](#)).

Acts 4:19–20

The apostles shared a principle that can guide God's people in dealing with hostile authorities (see also [5:40](#); compare [1 Samuel 15:22](#); [Jeremiah 7:23](#); [Luke 20:20–26](#); [Romans 13:1–7](#)). Jesus had predicted that his disciples would encounter hostility and persecution ([Luke 21:12–19](#)).

Acts 4:23–31

The believers heard the report that their leaders had been threatened and commanded never again to speak about Jesus ([4:18](#)). The Christian movement was clearly under attack from the religious authorities, so they united in prayer. They turned to God, sharing their troubles and asking for courage to speak the message. They also asked God to send signs and wonders to confirm that the message was true. God answered their request in a clear and powerful way.

Acts 4:25–26

This passage quotes [Psalm 2:1–2](#), which describes how the Gentile (non-Jewish) nations react to the Lord's anointed king. Similarly, the Jews and Gentiles in Jerusalem had gathered together against Jesus and now against his followers.

Acts 4:26

The Hebrew term *Messiah* (which means “anointed one”) originally referred to Israel's anointed king. Later, it referred to the Messiah, God's chosen future king of Israel who would establish God's kingdom forever ([2 Samuel 7:14–16](#); [Psalm 89:36–37](#); [Isaiah 9:6–7](#); [11:1–9](#); [61:1](#); [Jeremiah 23:5–6](#); [33:14–16](#); [Luke 1:32–33](#)).

Acts 4:28

God had been guiding events to fulfill his purpose. The Old Testament also shows God's guidance in his people's lives (see [Ezra 7:6](#), [9](#), [28](#); [8:18](#), [31](#); [Nehemiah 2:8](#), [18](#); [Ecclesiastes 9:1](#); [Ezekiel 8:1](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [1 Peter 5:6](#)).

Acts 4:32–35

The sharing among the early believers was remarkable (see also [2:44–45](#); compare [6:1](#)). They were united in heart and mind (they thought alike and shared the same purpose).

They freely shared what they owned to meet the needs of other believers. This sharing was voluntary and not forced. It responded to real needs in the community and was motivated by Christian love and care for one another.

Acts 4:36–37

Barnabas is presented as an example of generous and unselfish giving in response to real needs in the Christian community.

Acts 5:1–11

Luke likes to balance a positive example with a negative one. He just shared the remarkable and positive story of Barnabas ([4:36–37](#)). Now, Luke shows the opposite behavior of Ananias and Sapphira. This couple desired to earn status in the community and for others to admire them. Ananias did not have to sell his property or give away the money. Their sin was pretending and dishonesty.

Acts 5:3–4

By lying about the sale of their land, Ananias was not just being dishonest towards others but also toward the Holy Spirit. This means he was lying to God. His actions harmed the honesty, unity, and integrity of the church at its foundation. As a result, he experienced God's direct judgment (compare [Leviticus 10:1–5](#); [Joshua 7:16–26](#)).

Acts 5:11

great fear came over the whole church and all who heard about these events: The sudden judgment on Ananias and Sapphira had a serious impact on both the Christian community and those who learned about it (see [Hebrews 10:31](#)). Christians were strongly reminded to remain pure.

For non-Christians, the integrity of Christians was restored. So once again “the people regarded them highly” ([Acts 5:13](#)). However, it also made those outside the church cautious about joining a group with such high standards ([5:13](#)). This divine “pruning” allowed for new growth to occur (see [John 15:1–11](#); [Acts 5:14](#); see also [6:5–7](#); [11:24](#); [21:20](#)).

Acts 5:12–16

The preaching of the apostles included many miraculous signs and wonders, similar to the ministry of Jesus. There were also powerful acts of healing and casting out demons (see also [6:8](#); compare [Matthew 4:24](#); [9:35](#); [Mark 1:32–34](#); [Luke 4:40–41](#)).

Acts 5:13

- *Although the people regarded them highly:* People respected the believers because their way of life was different.

- *no one else dared to join them*: The people may have been afraid because of the high level of commitment expected of believers. They may also have feared what happened to Ananias and Sapphira (5:11).

Acts 5:17–40

The apostles' successful ministry caused strong opposition (compare 4:1–3). The wealthy and powerful Sadducees controlled the temple and had a temple police force. They opposed belief in the resurrection and were determined to challenge and, if possible, prevent the apostles from sharing their message about the resurrection of Jesus. They felt their influence over the Jewish people weakening. Jealousy and bitterness led them to attack the apostles.

Acts 5:19–20

The irony is that the Sadducees denied the existence of angels (23:8). However, angels appear many times in the book of Acts (see also 10:3, 7, 22; 11:13; 12:6–11, 23; 27:23–24). Luke shows God guiding his people in their ministry, using angels to carry out his purpose.

Acts 5:29

See study note on verses 4:19–20.

Acts 5:30–32

We are witnesses of these things: As witnesses, the apostles had the responsibility to speak about what they had seen and heard (see Leviticus 5:1; compare Acts 1:8; Matthew 28:18–20; Luke 24:44–49; John 20:21).

Acts 5:33–40

God once again stopped the plans of the Jewish leaders to silence the apostles. This time, he did so through the advice of Gamaliel.

Acts 5:34

Gamaliel was a respected Pharisee and a leading member of the Jewish high council. He was also a well-known teacher of the law. He later taught Paul during his training to become a Jewish rabbi (see 22:3).

Acts 5:36–37

- This Theudas is otherwise unknown, although the Jewish historian Josephus mentions a different man with the same name who led a revolution some years later (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.5.1). Theudas was a common Jewish name.
- Judas of Galilee appears in Josephus as a rebel who opposed paying taxes to Caesar around AD 6 or 7, following the census of Quirinius (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.5.2;

compare Luke 2:2). His resistance was stopped by the Roman authorities, who used force to end the revolt

Acts 6:1

- *the Grecian Jews*: The Greek-speaking Christians were Jewish Christians from other parts of the Greek and Roman world. They likely followed some Greek customs. The Hebrew-speaking Christians were more traditional Jews from Palestine. They spoke Hebrew or Aramaic and avoided Greek customs.
- *their widows were being overlooked*: This injustice threatened the church's growth and development. Overlooking needs from one group caused frustration and required an intentional response to correct the behavior.

Acts 6:2–6

- The apostles showed wisdom by calling a meeting of all the Christians to resolve the dispute. They understood that the problem was very serious. They also knew their priority was teaching God's word. They decided to choose men who were wise and filled with the Holy Spirit to manage the food distribution.

The community agreed with the plan the apostles proposed. They selected capable leaders from the Christians who spoke Greek (all of their names are Greek). These seven men focused on this special task, allowing the apostles to pray and teach.

- These seven men are sometimes called the first deacons because their role is similar to that of the office of deacon (see 1 Timothy 3:8–13). Although the Greek term translated “deacon” (Greek *diakonos*, “servant”) is not used here, a related Greek word is translated “to wait on tables” (6:2; Greek *diakonein*, “to serve”).

Acts 6:7

- The apostles were wise in how they dealt with the issue. This led to an increase in the number of Christians, including many of the Jewish priests.
- This is the first of three places in Acts where Luke notes that God's message continued to spread (see also 12:24; 19:20). When serious difficulties arose, God's message overcame internal conflict, idolatry, and pagan practices. As a result, the community continued to grow. The book of Acts tells the story of how the good news about Jesus spread without being stopped (see 28:31).

Acts 6:8–15

The Jewish leaders did to Stephen as they had done to Jesus (compare Matthew 26:3–4, 59–66):

- They found someone to lie about him,

- they accused him of blasphemy (saying offensive things about God),
- they started a riot,
- they arrested him, and
- they made false charges against him.

Acts 6:15

his face was like the face of an angel: This is similar to when the face of Moses “was radiant” after speaking with the Lord (6:14; see [Exodus 34:32–35](#)). Stephen, like Moses, was bringing God’s instruction to Israel (see also [2 Corinthians 3:7–18](#)).

Acts 7:1–53

- Stephen answered the accusations by speaking about his Lord (see [Luke 21:12–17](#)). Instead of defending himself, he became a witness in God’s legal case against them. This revealed how contrary they were and their lack of loyalty. Stephen gave a history of Israel’s past and reminded them of their repeated rejections of those who announced God’s messages.
- Stephen’s review of Israel’s history has three main parts:
 1. The work of the patriarchs. This refers to Abraham and those descended from him who founded the nation of Israel ([Acts 7:2–16](#)).
 2. The ministry of Moses ([7:17–43](#)).
 3. The role of the tabernacle and the temple ([7:44–50](#)).

Stephen ended his historical survey with a strong criticism of his people’s lack of obedience. Like a prophet, he challenged them to stop resisting the Holy Spirit. He told them to turn to God with grief for their sins (repentance) and faith.

Acts 7:8

the covenant of circumcision: See [Genesis 17:9–14](#). See also “Circumcision in the New Testament” Theme Note.

Acts 7:14

seventy-five: Compare this number with the seventy mentioned in the Hebrew text of [Genesis 46:27](#). The number seventy-five probably comes from the Septuagint, the ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament. The Septuagint includes three people descended from Ephraim and two of Manasseh in [46:20](#). This adds five more people. The Hebrew text does not include those descended from Joseph’s sons. New Testament authors mostly quote from the Septuagint, which sometimes differs from the Hebrew Masoretic Text.

Acts 7:16

a price: This was 400 pieces of silver, according to [Genesis 23:16](#).

Acts 7:37

a prophet like me: This verse quotes [Deuteronomy 18:15](#). Moses prophesied that the Messiah would come. It happened as Moses said.

Acts 7:39–40

The ancient Jews rejected the law Moses gave to them for their salvation. Stephen was speaking to the people of his time who were physical and spiritual descendants from those Jews. His point was that they were still rejecting God’s messengers. In this case, it was Jesus, the ultimate savior.

Acts 7:42–43

This passage quotes [Amos 5:25–27](#) (Greek version) to show how the people of Israel rebelled against Moses ([Acts 7:39–41](#)).

Molech was a Canaanite god to whom human sacrifices were offered ([Leviticus 18:21](#); [20:2–5](#); [1 Kings 11:7](#); [2 Kings 23:10](#); [Jeremiah 32:35](#)).

Rephan, a star god identified with the planet Saturn, was worshiped by the Israelites during their wilderness wanderings.

Acts 7:48–50

One charge against Stephen was that he spoke against the temple (see [6:14](#)). The leading priests and scribes managed the temple’s business and wanted to protect their interests (see [Luke 19:45–48](#)). This is why these leaders were concerned about the temple, even though God said that the Most High does not live in temples made by human hands.

Acts 7:51

Stephen accused the people of being stiff-necked with uncircumcised hearts and ears. This means they were strong-willed and ignored God’s truth. This was exactly how God had accused them of behaving during the time of wilderness wandering. Here, Stephen links it to rejecting the gospel and resisting the Holy Spirit (see [Exodus 32:9](#); [33:3](#); [34:9](#); [Deuteronomy 9:6](#), [13](#); [31:27](#); see also [Psalm 78:8](#); [Zechariah 7:11–12](#)).

Acts 7:55–56

- *standing at the right hand of God:* Usually, the Bible describes Jesus as seated in heaven at God’s right side ([2:33–34](#); [5:31](#); [Luke 20:42](#); [22:69](#); [Romans 8:34](#); [Ephesians 1:20](#); [Colossians 3:1](#); [Hebrews 1:3](#), [13](#); [10:12](#)). One possible explanation has been proposed by some church fathers that Jesus was welcoming Stephen to heaven with honor as the first New Testament martyr. Stephen was loyal in confessing his Lord on earth. Now

his Lord honored his promise to confess his loyal servant in heaven. Jesus was standing as a witness to defend him ([Matthew 10:32](#); [Luke 12:8](#)).

- *Son of Man standing*: Compare [Daniel 7:13–14](#). The Jewish leaders understood that Stephen was speaking of Jesus as the divine Son of Man ([Acts 7:57](#)). This title speaks of Jesus’s power and authority (compare [Revelation 1:12–15](#)).

Acts 7:57

They covered their ears because they thought comparing Jesus to the divine Son of Man was a terrible offense against God ([7:56](#)).

Acts 7:58

Saul was his name in Hebrew, and *Paul* was his Greek name (see [13:9](#)).

Acts 7:59–60

Stephen’s prayer, “Lord, do not hold this sin against them,” is very similar to the prayer Jesus prayed when he was on the cross ([Luke 23:34](#)). Jesus taught his followers the importance of forgiveness and prayer ([Matthew 6:14–15](#); [Mark 11:25](#); see [Luke 11:4](#); [17:3–4](#); [Luke 11:5–10](#); [18:1–8](#); see also [Acts 1:12–15](#); [4:23–31](#); [12:5](#); [James 5:16–18](#)). The Lord gave a positive answer to Stephen’s prayer as it relates to Saul ([Acts 9:1–43](#)).

Acts 8:1–4

Saul was there: Compare [9:1–2](#); [22:4](#); [26:9–11](#); [Galatians 1:13–14](#). This major attack against the church caused all believers except the apostles to flee. Instead of losing enthusiasm, they preached the good news about Jesus wherever they went.

Acts 8:7

Came out ... healed: Miracles often happen when the gospel is preached in the book of Acts (see study note on [3:1–11](#)).

Acts 8:9–24

Simon the sorcerer performed magic and amazed the people of Samaria. He boasted that he was someone great. Simon tried to buy spiritual power. The later corrupt practice of buying and selling positions of leadership in the church was called *simony*. This term refers to the corrupt practice of buying and selling church leadership positions (see [1 Timothy 6:9–10](#)). Peter strongly criticized Simon’s evil intentions and actions.

Acts 8:14–17

When the apostles sent two of their own representatives to Samaria, it was an important step in overcoming prejudice (compare [Matthew 10:5](#); [Luke 9:52–54](#); [John 4:9](#); [8:48](#)). It was even more remarkable that Peter and John prayed for the Samaritans who trusted in Christ to receive the Holy Spirit. This event is similar to the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem and marks how the Holy Spirit’s power spread from Judea to Samaria ([Acts 2:1–47](#); [1:8](#)).

Acts 8:24

Simon recognized that he needed Peter to pray for him. However, the text does not clearly say that Simon repented or turned away from his evil actions. His request seems focused on avoiding the severe punishment Peter warned about, rather than on a true change in how he thought and acted.

Acts 8:26–40

Philip obeyed the Holy Spirit and followed the Spirit’s direction. He then took the opportunity to share the message of the gospel with an Ethiopian eunuch (a trusted male official who served a king or queen) on the desert road from Jerusalem to Gaza. This event shows how effective Philip was in explaining and sharing the Christian message. It also shows his strong commitment to bringing the good news to all people, no matter their social position or ethnic background.

Acts 8:27

- In the ancient world, a eunuch was a royal official. Some eunuchs had been physically altered and could not have children, while others held the title because of their role in the royal court (see [2 Kings 9:30–32](#); [Esther 1:10](#); [2:3, 14–15, 21](#); [4:4–5](#)).

Many Jews looked down on eunuchs. Eunuchs could not have children, so they could not pass on the covenant family line (God’s people through descendants). The law of Moses also excluded men with damaged genitals from the assembly of Israel, which was the gathered worshipping community ([Deuteronomy 23:1](#); compare [Leviticus 21:17–23](#)).

However, the prophet Isaiah spoke of a future time when God would welcome non-Jewish people and eunuchs who were faithful to him ([Isaiah 56:3–8](#); see also [Matthew 19:12](#)). In the new covenant, all people who have genuine faith belong to the people of God.

- The eunuch traveled from Africa to Jerusalem to worship in the temple, probably for a major Jewish feast.

Acts 8:29

The Holy Spirit guides the servants of God in where, when, and what to preach, teach, or do (Acts 9:15; 10:19–20; 11:12; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 2:13; 1 Peter 1:12).

Acts 8:32–33

The Scripture passage was [Isaiah 53:7–8](#). It is one of the Servant Songs of Isaiah, a passage that speaks of the suffering servant of the Lord.

Acts 8:39–40

- After the Spirit of the Lord carried Philip away, he traveled north along the coast from Azotus. Azotus is another name for Ashdod (see [1 Samuel 5:1–7](#); [Nehemiah 13:23–24](#); [Isaiah 20:1](#)). He preached in every town until he reached Caesarea, where he later settled (see [Acts 21:8](#)).
- *Caesarea*: Caesarea Maritima was a major port on the Mediterranean Sea. It was the center of Roman government in Judea. Herod the Great built it around 22 to 9 BC and named it to honor Caesar Augustus, the Roman emperor.

Acts 9:1–19

The conversion of Saul of Tarsus on the Damascus road is central to the story in Acts. Luke tells the story three times (also [22:1–21](#); [26:1–29](#)). Paul (Saul) mentions this experience several times in his letters ([1 Corinthians 15:8–10](#); [Galatians 1:11–17](#); [Philippians 3:4–11](#); see [1 Timothy 1:12–17](#)). Saul's conversion was his call as a prophet and commission as an apostle ([Acts 9:15](#); [22:15](#), [21](#); [26:15–18](#)). No one is beyond God's power to reach, save, and use for holy purposes. Nothing is impossible with God ([Luke 1:37](#)). God prepared Paul through his training, childhood, and experience to play a unique role in proclaiming the gospel to the wider world as the "apostle to the Gentiles" ([Romans 11:13](#); see [1 Corinthians 15:9](#); [2 Corinthians 12:11–12](#); [Galatians 1:1](#); [Ephesians 3:8](#)).

Acts 9:2

- A synagogue (Greek *sunagōgē*, meaning "gathering place") was a local Jewish meeting place. After the exile to Babylon, Jewish people began to meet in synagogues in their towns. These places became centers for teaching and worship. After Israel returned from exile in Babylon, Jews began using synagogues for instruction and worship.

In the synagogue, people read from the Law and the Prophets. Leaders explained the meaning of the Scriptures. The people also prayed and gave praise and thanks to God (see [13:15](#); [15:21](#); [Nehemiah 9:5](#); [Matthew 6:5](#); [Luke 4:16–21](#)).

Jesus attended, taught, preached, and performed miracles in synagogues ([Matthew 12:9–10](#); [Mark 1:21](#), [39](#); [Luke 4:16](#); [13:10–13](#); [John 6:59](#); [18:20](#)). His apostles did as well (see [Acts 9:20](#); [13:5](#), [14](#); [14:1](#); [17:1](#), [10](#), [17](#); [18:4](#), [19](#), [26](#)).

- *Damascus*: Damascus, the capital of Syria, was an important center with a long history. It was the nearest major city outside of Palestine. It took four to six days to travel from Jerusalem to Damascus. This emphasizes Saul's determination ([9:1–5](#); see [22:4–8](#); [26:9–15](#)).
- *the Way*: The term *the Way* in the book of Acts refers to Christianity (see [19:9](#), [23](#); [24:14](#), [22](#)). It is "the way of God" that teaches people "the way of salvation" ([18:26](#); [16:17](#)). See also [John 14:6](#); [2 Peter 2:2](#).

Acts 9:10

- *Ananias*: See also [22:12](#). Ananias was a common name (consider the husband of Sapphira, [5:1](#), and the Jewish high priest [AD 47–59], [23:2](#)).
- *a vision*: See "Visions" Theme Note.

Acts 9:15

This man is My chosen instrument to carry My name before the Gentiles: In God's plan to spread the good news, the next step was to reach the Gentiles, that is, people from other nations (see [1:8](#); compare chapters [10–11](#)).

Saul of Tarsus, also called Paul, was the one God chose for this task. God sent him to bring the message about Jesus to Gentiles, to kings, and also to the people of Israel.

The rest of the book of Acts shows how Paul faithfully carried out this mission from God (for example, [26:19–23](#)).

Acts 9:16

As Jesus predicted, Paul suffered greatly for his faith (see [2 Corinthians 11:23–27](#); see [Acts 13:45](#); [14:19](#); [16:22–27](#); [21:30–31](#); [26:21](#); [2 Timothy 1:11–12](#)).

Acts 9:17

God gave Ananias a special role. He was to welcome Saul into the Christian community.

Ananias began by placing his hands on Saul. Through this act, Saul was healed and filled with the Holy Spirit.

Acts 9:20–21

Saul promptly began to proclaim Jesus: Saul's encounter with the heavenly Christ was genuine, shown by his enthusiastic and bold preaching. His direct declaration surprised many because he had previously caused great harm to the followers of Jesus in Jerusalem.

Acts 9:22–25

The people who heard Saul were confused and surprised. Even so, Saul clearly showed from the Scriptures that Jesus is the Messiah. His arguments were so strong that the Jews in Damascus who did not believe could not answer him.

This continued for some time (see [Galatians 1:18](#)). The people who heard Saul were confused and surprised. Even so, Saul clearly showed from the Scriptures that Jesus is the Messiah. His arguments were so strong that the Jews in Damascus who did not believe could not answer him.

This continued for some time in [2 Corinthians 11:32–33](#).

Acts 9:26–28

When Saul arrived in Jerusalem: The believers did not trust him at first. This was understandable. He had recently attacked and imprisoned Christians ([8:3](#); [9:1](#), [13](#); [22:3](#), [4](#); [26:9–11](#)).

Barnabas helped him. Barnabas, whose name means “Son of Encouragement” ([4:36](#)), brought Saul to the apostles. He told them how Saul had seen the Lord on the road to Damascus. He also explained how Saul had preached boldly in the name of Jesus there.

Barnabas convinced the apostles that Saul’s conversion was real. So Saul stayed with them in Jerusalem. There, he continued to preach boldly about the Lord.

Paul later spoke about this visit in [Galatians 1:18–19](#).

Acts 9:29

Once again, Saul debated with some Greek-speaking Jews. He spoke boldly and explained why Jesus is the Messiah.

Again, some people became angry and made a plan to kill him (see [9:22–24](#)).

Acts 9:30

After the Christians heard about the plot, they sent Saul away again (see [9:25](#)). This time he went to Tarsus, his hometown, the capital of Cilicia (see [21:39](#); [22:3](#); [23:34](#); compare [Galatians 1:21](#)).

Acts 9:31

- This verse is one of several in Acts that describe how the church grew in numbers and in faithfulness (see also [2:41](#); [4:4](#); [5:14](#); [6:1](#), [7](#); [12:24](#); [21:20](#)).
- The first Christians were learning an important truth: “The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.” This means that true knowledge starts with honoring and respecting God ([Proverbs 1:7](#); [9:10](#); compare [Job 28:28](#); [Psalm 111:10](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:13](#); see [Luke 7:16](#)).

As they learned to honor God, they grew stronger in their faith. Their reverence for the Lord helped the church grow (compare [Acts 2:43](#); [19:17](#)).

Acts 9:32–43

- These verses describe Peter’s traveling ministry in Judea, especially in towns along the seacoast. As he traveled, God gave him power to do miracles. Peter healed a man named Aeneas and raised a woman named Dorcas from the dead.

Jesus had promised that his disciples would do such works ([John 14:12](#)).

- Luke often tells stories in pairs. For example, he tells of a man being healed and then a woman being healed (see [Luke 13:10–17](#); [14:1–6](#)). In this passage, Peter heals both a man and a woman.

The people in that area were deeply affected by these miracles. Many people turned to the Lord and believed ([Acts 9:35](#), [42](#)).

Acts 9:43

stayed for several days in Joppa with a tanner named Simon: A tanner worked with animal skins to make leather. This job required contact with dead animals.

Many Jews considered this kind of work unclean. Because Peter stayed in the home of a tanner, it may show that he was not strict about some Jewish traditions (see [Galatians 2:11–14](#)).

Acts 10:1–8

- *a centurion:* This was the highest rank for an officer in the Roman army who was not commissioned. He led a *century*, a group of about 100 men. Luke often describes centurions positively ([10:22](#); [21:32](#); [22:25–26](#); [23:17](#), [23](#); [27:6](#), [11](#), [43](#); [28:16](#); [Luke 7:1–10](#); [23:47](#)).

Luke wanted to show that Christianity was not against Roman officials or institutions. It could, like Judaism, be permitted in the Roman Empire (see Acts Book Introduction, “Purposes of Acts: Politics”).

- *in what was called the Italian Regiment:* A regiment included six centuries; a Roman legion was usually divided into ten regiments. The New Testament mentions the Italian Regiment and the Imperial Regiment ([Acts 27:1](#)).

Acts 10:2

devout and God-fearing: Gentiles described as God-fearing admired Judaism’s high ethical standards. However, they were not ready to undergo circumcision or fully convert to Judaism (see [13:43](#)).

Christianity appealed to these Gentiles who worshiped God ([18:7](#); see [13:48](#); [16:30](#); [17:4](#), [12](#), [17](#)). These individuals were

open to the message of the gospel that announced that “there is peace with God through Jesus Christ” (10:36).

Acts 10:3

In Acts, visions often happen while people are praying (9:3–6, 10–16; 10:2–6, 9–12; 11:5–9; 12:9–17; 18:9–10; 22:17–21; 23:11). These visions are not random. They show God’s saving work and give divine guidance and encouragement.

Acts 10:9–16

God gave Peter the same vision three times to confirm it was true (see [Genesis 41:32](#); [2 Corinthians 13:1](#)).

Acts 10:14

See [Leviticus 11](#) for a list of animals that Jewish laws have declared impure and ceremonially unclean.

Acts 10:17

Peter was puzzling over: The events that followed would clarify the meaning of the vision (10:17–48; see 11:1–18). Peter should not hesitate to enter or eat in a non-Jewish (Gentile) home because God has accepted and cleansed them.

Acts 10:25–26

Cornelius ... fell at his feet to worship him: This act was probably more than just bowing to an important person of rank. The Bible says worship is for God alone (see 14:11–17; [Exodus 20:3](#); [Deuteronomy 5:7](#); [Matthew 22:37–38](#); [Mark 12:29–30](#); [Luke 10:27](#); [1 Corinthians 10:14](#); [Colossians 3:5](#); [1 Peter 4:3](#); [1 John 5:21](#); [Revelation 4:10](#); 9:20; 22:8–9).

Peter was just a fellow human being whom Cornelius should not worship.

Acts 10:34–35

- *God does not show favoritism:* See [Deuteronomy 10:17](#); [2 Chronicles 19:7](#); [Job 34:19](#); [Luke 20:21](#); [Romans 2:11](#); [Galatians 2:6](#); [Colossians 3:25](#); [1 Peter 1:17](#).

The application of this principle is the meaning of Peter’s vision (10:9–16).

- *welcomes those from every nation who fear Him and do what is right:* See [Romans 10:11–13](#).

Acts 10:36–43

Peter often emphasizes the role of the apostles as witnesses to the good news (the message about Jesus’s life, death, and resurrection). He reminds his listeners that they had direct contact with Jesus.

The apostles ate and drank with Jesus after he rose from the dead (see [Luke 24:41–43](#)). They saw him alive again. Because they were eyewitnesses of his resurrection, they could testify that Jesus had defeated death (see [Acts 3:15](#); [4:33](#); [13:30–31](#)).

Jesus chose the original apostles ahead of time to be his witnesses (see 1:12–26). Later, others continued this work. For example, Paul and Barnabas preached and taught in the name of Jesus Christ (see 9:15; 14:1–3; 26:16).

Acts 10:43

- Based on what they saw and heard, the apostles could declare that Jesus of Nazareth was the one about whom all the prophets spoke (10:39–42). The whole message and purpose of Scripture center on Christ (see [Luke 24:25–27](#), [44–47](#); [John 5:39](#)).
- The main point of their message was that everyone who believes in Jesus will have sins forgiven through his name (see [Luke 24:47](#)).

Acts 10:44–48

On the day of Pentecost, Peter told the people that if they stopped sinning, repented, asked forgiveness from God, and received baptism in the name of Jesus Christ, they would “receive the gift of the Holy Spirit” (2:38; see also 19:1–7).

As Cornelius and his household listened to Peter’s message, they received the Holy Spirit just like the Jews had earlier. This event confirmed again that God did not favor one group over another (10:34–35). This event is similar to the day of Pentecost in Jerusalem (2:1–47). It shows that the power of the Holy Spirit now came to the Gentiles as well (1:8; 2:39).

Acts 10:48

Cornelius asked Peter to stay for a few days with them, possibly because he needed more instruction in the Christian faith.

Acts 11:1–18

Jews traditionally kept themselves separate and did not eat or interact in a social setting with Gentiles (10:28; 22:21–22; see [John 4:9, 27](#); [18:28](#); [Galatians 2:12–14](#)). The Jewish Christians in Jerusalem learned that Gentiles had received the word of God. Then they criticized Peter’s unusual actions and asked for an explanation, which Peter provided.

Acts 11:4–17

Peter reviewed what had happened. He explained that God had directed the whole series of events (11:12). Peter ate with Gentiles (non-Jews) because God made it evident that he should (11:4–12). Peter then saw the Holy Spirit come upon the Gentiles, realizing God accepted and blessed them like

Jews who trusted in Jesus (11:15–17; see 1:5). Peter followed God’s will by admitting Gentiles to the church.

Acts 11:18

Peter gave a clear and careful explanation. Those who had objected were convinced. They saw that God was at work in the Gentiles’ believing in Jesus and in their receiving eternal life.

However, the question of including Gentiles was not finished. Soon it would lead to a serious crisis in the church (15:1–35; see also Paul’s letter to the Galatians).

Acts 11:19–26

- After Stephen’s death, persecution forced Christians to move to other areas (8:1–3). They traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch.
- Antioch in Syria was a busy, diverse city. It was the third-largest city in the Roman Empire, after Rome and Alexandria. Antioch played a key role in spreading the Christian message to non-Jewish people.

Acts 11:20

Jewish Christians from Cyprus and Cyrene made the first organized effort to teach Gentiles about Jesus.

Acts 11:21–24

As with the household of Cornelius, many Gentiles believed in Jesus. The growth of Christian faith among Gentiles had to remain in harmony with the church at Jerusalem. So, the Jerusalem Christians sent Barnabas to Antioch to oversee the developments there. Barnabas could see that God’s blessing was on what was happening, so he supported it with joy.

Acts 11:25–26

Barnabas saw that Saul had a special gift for preaching and teaching. The wise judgment of Barnabas led to a successful ministry in Antioch.

Acts 11:26

The term *Christians* might have first been an insult. The Greek text uses this term in only two other New Testament passages (26:28; 1 Peter 4:16).

Acts 11:27–28

- *some prophets*: See “The Gift of Prophecy” Theme Note.
- *Agabus*: See also 21:10–12.

Acts 11:28

Claudius was the nephew of Tiberius Caesar (Luke 3:1). He ruled as Roman emperor from AD 41 to AD 54.

His last wife was his niece Agrippina. Claudius adopted her son, Nero.

Acts 11:29–30

Agabus’s prophecy resulted in the Christians in Antioch helping the Jewish Christians in Judea. They gave as much as they could and trusted the funds to Barnabas and Saul. This act of love and support showed the difference Jesus had made in their lives. Saul (also called Paul) mentions this visit in his letter to the Galatians (Galatians 2:1–10).

Acts 11:30

This is the first mention in the book of Acts of elders as officers in the Christian church (see also 14:23; 15:2–23; 16:4; 20:17–35; 21:18; compare 1 Timothy 3:1–7; Titus 1:5–9).

Acts 12:1–5

- Jesus had prophesied that his followers would experience persecution and difficulty (Luke 11:49–51). For the first time since his death, Roman authorities acted violently against the church. James, the brother of John, was among the first disciples Jesus called (Mark 1:16–20; Luke 5:1–11). He was one of the first Christians killed because of his faith.
- King Herod Agrippa took action to intentionally harm the church (Acts 12:20–23). It is possible that doing this was meant to strengthen his political alignment with the Jewish people. The letter of James, the brother of Jesus, was probably written after this persecution effort to the Christians who were scattered (see 8:1–4; James Book Introduction, “Date of Writing”).

Acts 12:4

Herod had Peter guarded by four squads of soldiers, making it impossible for the apostle to escape (compare 12:6). God was in control, even though the circumstances seemed impossible for humans to overcome (compare 4:27–31; Genesis 18:14; Jeremiah 32:17, 27; Matthew 19:26; Mark 10:27; Luke 1:37; 18:27).

Acts 12:5

the church was fervently praying: God answers the earnest prayers of his people (12:6–17; see Luke 11:1–13; 18:1–8; compare Matthew 7:7–11; John 15:7; Philippians 4:6–7; James 5:16; 1 John 3:22).

Acts 12:6–19

God, through an angel, guided Peter out of prison. Peter reunited with his praying friends, and God sent him to continue proclaiming the good news about Jesus. The message advanced by God's power, even when the church and apostles faced strong opposition and discouragement.

Acts 12:7–11

See “Angels” Theme Note.

Acts 12:12

Mary, the mother of John Mark, had a home where Christians often gathered. John Mark later worked with Barnabas and Saul to spread the gospel (12:25).

Acts 12:13–17

Rhoda was very surprised when Peter appeared, so she left him standing at the closed door. She and the other Christians thought God's answer to their prayers was amazing (12:5).

Acts 12:18–23

When Peter was missing after a thorough search, Herod questioned the guards and executed them (see 16:27). However, Herod himself then experienced a painful death. God punished him for his pride when he accepted the people's worship. The ancient Jewish historian Josephus provides more details about the death of Herod Agrippa I (Josephus, *Antiquities* 19.8.1–2).

Acts 12:24–25

Herod died from a terrible illness (12:23). Meanwhile, the Christian church continued to grow and share the message of the gospel freely (28:31).

Acts 13:1

- *prophets and teachers*: See “The Gift of Prophecy” Theme Note; also see 1 Corinthians 12:28–29; Ephesians 4:11.
- The name Simeon suggests a Jewish background (see Genesis 29:33; Luke 2:25; 3:30). He is also called Niger (which means “the black mane”). This suggests that he was probably African.
- Lucius is a Latin name. He came from Cyrene, the capital of Libya in North Africa. He was probably one of the preachers from Cyrene who brought the Christian message to Antioch (Acts 11:20).
- Manaen grew up with King Herod Antipas. He was probably Luke's source for understanding Antipas's thoughts and actions (see Luke 9:7–9).
- Barnabas and Saul play important roles in the following story.

Acts 13:1–3

prophets and teachers: these leaders of the church at Antioch spent a lot of time in worship and prayer. They had an intense desire to do the Lord's will, and they fasted to spiritually prepare themselves to receive guidance from God. As they prayed, the Holy Spirit spoke to them.

The church set apart Barnabas and Saul, recognizing God's clear call for them to do a special work in his name. The inner journey these Christians took to pray and listen to God matched their outer journey of service. Their service included proclaiming the Christian faith and performing works of healing and salvation.

Acts 13:3

they laid their hands on them: They performed this holy act only after more fasting and prayer. The Pastoral Letters (1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) caution against appointing someone as a Christian leader without proper care and background checks (1 Timothy 5:22). At this point, the church at Antioch sent Barnabas and Saul as its representatives for the mission.

Acts 13:4

- Barnabas and Saul were commissioned by the church at Antioch to go on their first missionary journey. They were guided by the Holy Spirit.
- Seleucia was the ancient seaport city of Antioch, about 20 kilometers (12 miles) west of the city at the opening of the Orontes River.
- *from there to Cyprus*: Barnabas was from Cyprus, the next stop on their journey (4:36).

Acts 13:5

When they arrived in Salamis on the eastern end of Cyprus, they visited the Jewish synagogues (see study note on 9:2). There, Jews could hear and respond to the Christian message. They would also meet people who had converted to Judaism (those who had chosen to follow Israel's God; see study note on 13:43). They also met Gentiles (non-Jews) who were seeking God. These Gentiles are sometimes called *God-fearers* (people who worshiped the God of Israel but had not fully become Jews; see study note on 10:2).

Acts 13:6

- *Paphos*: This major city was on the southwest coast of Cyprus, a location that had strategic significance.
- *a Jewish sorcerer and false prophet named Bar-Jesus*: People from the east who practiced magic like this man often had significant power to influence people in the Greek and Roman world.

Acts 13:6–12

In Paphos, a false prophet caused a power struggle. This resulted in a display of God's power, and the Roman proconsul (governor) became a Christian.

Acts 13:7–8

Sergius Paulus, the proconsul (governor), was an intelligent person. He had interest in the teachings of Barnabas and Saul. But Elymas (the sorcerer's Greco-Roman name) recognized a challenge to his power and strongly opposed the message of Barnabas and Saul.

Acts 13:9

Luke marks an important shift in using the name Saul (a Hebrew name) and Paul (a Greco-Roman name). This may show that Paul is now focusing on his mission to Gentiles (non-Jews). For the rest of Acts, Luke calls him Paul, except when Paul tells the story of his conversion (as in [22:7](#), [13:26:14](#)).

Acts 13:10–11

Paul, who had become the main speaker, confronted the sorcerer. He rebuked his false claims, exposed his deceit, and announced God's judgment (see [8:20–24](#)). The sorcerer became blind immediately, and this condition lasted for a significant period of time. This event showed the power and truthfulness of the gospel message over the sorcerer's false claims.

Acts 13:12

The teaching about the Lord included a miracle showing divine power (compare [Mark 1:21–27](#)). This was because it was a teaching about the living God (see [Acts 14:15](#)).

Acts 13:13–14

- They arrived at the port of Perga. From there, major roads led to the interior of the land beyond the Taurus Mountains.
- At this point, John Mark left the team for unknown reasons (see study note on [15:36–41](#)). He might have been unhappy that the gospel was advancing into non-Jewish lands. Perhaps he missed his home or was unable to continue the challenging journey. Whatever the reasons, he returned to the familiar and comfortable Jewish area of Jerusalem.

Acts 13:14

Paul and Barnabas traveled inland to the high country and reached Pisidian Antioch. This Antioch was in the Roman province of Galatia in Asia Minor. This city is not the same one as the city of Antioch in Syria.

As usual, the apostles began their work at the synagogue (see study note on [9:2](#); compare [13:5](#); [14:1](#); [17:1](#), [2](#), [10](#), [17](#); [18:4](#), [19](#); [19:8](#)).

Acts 13:15

People chosen to read in the synagogue read the usual Scriptures for the day. This included one passage from the books of Moses and another from the prophets (see [Luke 4:16–28](#)). Then the synagogue leaders invited the visitors to share a word of encouragement for the people.

Acts 13:16–41

Paul accepted the invitation, and signaled for his audience to be quiet (compare [19:33](#); [21:40](#)). He began to clearly proclaim the good news about Jesus. This is Paul's first major speech in the book of Acts. It serves as a model of the way he preached to a Jewish audience (see [22:1–21](#)).

Acts 13:17–22

To establish common ground with his audience, Paul traced Jewish history starting from the Israelite exodus from Egypt. He emphasized:

- the Israelites' escape from Egyptian slavery,
- their settlement in Canaan,
- the establishment of the kingdom of Israel,
- the removal of King Saul, and
- the special role of King David.

Acts 13:22

Even though he sinned, David was a man who desired to completely follow God's ways (for example, [2 Samuel 11–12](#)).

Acts 13:23–25

At this point, Paul shifted to the main point of his message. Jesus, descended from King David's family line, was the Savior God promised to Israel. John the Baptist prepared the way for the Messiah (God's chosen leader). John called Israel to repent and be baptized. John was a humble servant who prepared the way for the one whose coming he announced.

Acts 13:26–37

Paul reviewed how Jesus had been treated with shame, including an unjust sentence and death. But God raised Jesus from the dead, and many witnesses saw him. This message is good news, because through Jesus people can receive forgiveness of sins. But people must respond with faith, or they will face serious consequences.

Acts 13:31

The resurrection of Jesus was confirmed by many witnesses.

Acts 13:38–41

Paul urged his audience to believe the message about Jesus, through whom there is forgiveness for your sins.

Acts 13:39

A life of faith is necessary to be right with God. The law of Moses alone could not provide this ability to have a right relationship ([Psalm 14:1–3](#); see [Romans 3:9–20](#)).

Acts 13:40–41

Paul ended his message with a strong warning (see [Hebrews 2:3](#)). Do not ignore, neglect, or reject the gospel, or you will encounter serious consequences.

Acts 13:42–43

The message attracted many people, and many of them chose to believe.

Acts 13:43

- Full converts to Judaism (also called *proselytes*) were Gentiles who had gone through the rite of circumcision to become full members of the Jewish community, observing the Jewish law (see also [2:11](#); [6:5](#); [Matthew 23:15](#)).
- *the grace of God*: The grace of God is an important idea in the New Testament. It describes God's kindness and favor that people do not earn, shown most clearly through Jesus Christ.

Acts 13:44–49

The excitement caused by the apostles' preaching led to a mass turnout on the following week. This response provoked the jealousy of some of the Jews (cp. [4:1–2](#); [5:17](#)), whose ability to win converts to Judaism ([13:43](#)) was being dwarfed by Paul's ministry. They verbally attacked Paul and his ministry (cp. [6:8–12](#); [18:6](#); [19:9](#); [Matt 23:13](#)). Paul met this hostility with a bold declaration that these Jews had had their opportunity to hear the word of God, and that since they had rejected it, the offer of salvation would now be given to the Gentiles (cp. [Acts 10:34–35](#)), in accord with the Lord's command in Scripture. The local Gentiles welcomed the Good News and many responded to it, so the Lord's message was carried throughout that region.

Acts 13:50–51

Jewish opposition once again forced Paul and Barnabas . . . out of town. They shook the dust from their feet as a sign of rejection, as Jesus had taught his disciples (see [Matt 10:14–15](#); [Mark 6:11–12](#); [Luke 9:5–6](#); [10:10–11](#)). That place was then treated as pagan territory, and other people were given access to the message of new life in Christ.

Acts 13:52

Despite probable harassment and persecution, the believers were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit (cp. [5:41](#); [16:23–25](#); [Matt 5:10–12](#); [2 Cor 8:2](#); [1 Thes 1:6](#)).

Acts 14:1

The missionaries moved on to the next town, Iconium (now called Konya), located east of Pisidian Antioch on a high plateau in south central Asia Minor. Iconium enjoyed a favorable location on several key trade routes. • In their usual fashion, Paul and Barnabas began their ministry in the area by speaking powerfully in the Jewish synagogue, which led to a great response from both Jews and Greeks.

Acts 14:2

Once again Paul and Barnabas faced hostile Jews who rejected the Christian message and also poisoned the minds of the Gentiles.

Acts 14:3

The Spirit-inspired apostles were resilient to withstand the verbal attack against them, and they persisted in preaching the Good News that God's grace was available to Gentiles as well as to Jews. • boldly: Spirit-inspired boldness is evident throughout Acts (see [2:14](#); [4:9–10](#), [13](#); [7:2–53](#); [8:30–35](#); [9:27–28](#); [18:26](#); [19:8](#); [22:3–21](#); [23:1–6](#); [28:16–20](#), [23–31](#)). • In addition, the Holy Spirit confirmed the Christian message with miraculous signs and wonders (cp. [5:12–16](#); [15:12](#); [16:18](#); [19:11](#)).

Acts 14:4

The apostolic message required a decision about belief in Jesus, and opinion was clearly split. • Paul and Barnabas are called apostles for the first time (also in [14:14](#)), extending the idea of apostleship beyond the Twelve. Their message was in continuity with that of the original apostles, and they were prepared to suffer hardship and persecution for it as the earlier apostles had done ([5:41](#); [14:19](#); [20:24](#); [21:13–14](#); see also [Rom 8:35–38](#); [2 Cor 4:8–17](#)).

Acts 14:6

Lycaonia was a southern region of the Roman province of Galatia. Its major cities were Lystra, Derbe, Laranda, and Iconium. Acts reports two more visits by Paul to Lycaonia ([16:1–5](#); [18:23](#)). Paul's letter to the Galatians was probably addressed to scattered believers in the churches of Lycaonia (see Galatians Book Introduction, "Recipients"). • Lystra was located roughly twenty-five miles (40 km) south-southwest of Iconium. • Derbe, situated about thirty miles (50 km) southeast of Lystra, was on the busy major road that

stretched from Iconium and Lystra eastward to Tarsus, the capital of Cilicia.

Acts 14:8–20

Paul's healing of a man with crippled feet recalls a similar incident in 3:1–12. In Acts, the work of Paul parallels the work of Peter, and the many miraculous signs and wonders performed among the Jews were also performed among the Gentiles.

Acts 14:9

Paul realized he had faith to be healed: Paul, full of the Holy Spirit (9:17), sensed the man's spiritual openness and expectancy for divine help and intervention.

Acts 14:11–13

Zeus was the patron god of Lystra, and the city had a temple in his honor. They associated Barnabas with Zeus, perhaps because he was the more impressive figure, and Hermes was identified with Paul . . . since he was the chief speaker. The native people of Lystra thought that they were being treated to a divine visitation similar to a past mythological appearance cited by the poet Ovid (in which the gods Zeus and Hermes came to visit the area but were unrecognized except by an old couple; see Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.616–724). So the people set out to honor these supposed gods.

Acts 14:13–18

The apostles opposed the people's idolatry and their attempt to offer sacrifices to them. They directed the people's worship to the living God; the apostles were his representatives as they brought the Good News of the Christian message.

Acts 14:19–20

The crowd became fickle when some Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium and easily turned the people against the apostles. • They stoned Paul and dragged him out of town: Paul later referred to this time of persecution as a lesson (2 Tim 3:11–12). • thinking he was dead: That Paul got up and went back into the town suggests that God miraculously healed him of his wounds.

Acts 14:20

The next day he left: Paul later returned to Lystra on his second missionary journey (16:1).

Acts 14:22–23

The apostles were diligent in following up with those who had made a Christian profession of faith. These new disciples needed to be nurtured, supported, and encouraged (15:32, 41; 16:40; 18:23; see 1 Thes 3:2; 4:18; 5:14). • Paul and

Barnabas ... appointed elders: See "Church Leaders" Theme Note.

Acts 14:26–28

As soon as Paul and Barnabas returned home to Antioch from their first missionary journey, they called the church together and gave a full report of their evangelism and discipleship. They humbly acknowledged divine guidance in opening the door of faith to the Gentiles (see 11:18; 1 Cor 16:9; 2 Cor 2:12). Similar reports (Acts 15:4, 12; 21:19) always stressed the activity of God as working through the ministries of his servants (see Rom 15:17–18; 1 Cor 3:5–9; 15:10–11).

Acts 15:1

These men from Judea were Jewish Christians who taught the necessity of circumcision (and with it, conversion to Judaism) in order to be saved. The central issue was how Gentiles were to be received into Christian fellowship. Paul wrote his letter to the Galatians about this time to counter the same teaching in Galatia (see Galatians Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").

Acts 15:2–3

The Antioch church decided to send . . . delegates to Jerusalem to resolve this matter in discussion with the apostles and elders there. En route, the entourage visited believers in Phoenicia and Samaria, where the Christian faith had made substantial inroads (ch 8).

Acts 15:4–21

The first council of the church met to resolve the dispute concerning Gentiles and circumcision (15:1–2).

Acts 15:5

These Pharisees were believers, yet they retained their strong adherence to the law of Moses. Paul argued against their message most strenuously (see Gal 1:6–9; 2:14–3:14).

Acts 15:7–11

Peter, no doubt remembering his own experience in the household of Cornelius (ch 10), argued that God had already confirmed his acceptance of the Gentiles without circumcision by giving them the Holy Spirit. The undeserved grace of the Lord Jesus had been made available to all.

Acts 15:13–19

James, the brother of Jesus, declared that the conversion of the Gentiles was clearly in accord with Scripture. He argued forcefully that it was contrary to the divine will to put unnecessary requirements on the admission of the Gentiles.

Acts 15:14

Peter: Greek *Simeon*. Peter's given name was Simon (see [Matt 16:17–19](#)).

Acts 15:15–19

Because God's prophets had predicted the conversion and inclusion of the Gentiles, James argued that the Gentiles should be accepted as Gentiles, without requiring them to practice Judaism ([15:1](#)).

Acts 15:20

Eating food offered to idols is sinful if it involves knowingly partaking of an idolatrous sacrifice (see [Exod 20:4](#); [Deut 5:8](#); [1 Cor 8:4–13](#); [10:14–30](#); [Rev 2:14, 20](#)). • Sexual immorality was common in the Greek world but is always sinful ([Exod 20:14](#); [Deut 5:18](#); [Gal 5:19](#)). • eating the meat of strangled animals: God's law prohibits eating meat that has blood in it ([Lev 17:13–14](#)) or consuming blood ([Lev 17:10–12](#)), “for the life of every creature is in its blood” ([Lev 17:14](#)). Also, “It is the blood, given in exchange for a life, that makes purification possible” (see [Lev 17:11](#) and study note). This command was first given to Noah, the ancestor of Gentiles as well as Jews ([Gen 9:4](#)).

Acts 15:22–29

The Jerusalem church chose two of the church leaders to report its decision. They took with them a letter from the apostles and elders . . . in Jerusalem explaining the terms of the agreement.

Acts 15:29

Farewell: The letter to the churches includes this familiar Hellenistic greeting at the end of a letter, found only here in the New Testament. Paul often ended his letters on a more theological note (e.g., [1 Cor 16:23–24](#); [2 Cor 13:13](#); see [Eph 6:23–24](#); [Phil 4:23](#); [Col 4:18](#); [1 Thes 5:23–28](#); [1 Tim 6:21](#)).

Acts 15:30–31

The believers at Antioch received the decision with great joy that conversion to Judaism and keeping all the requirements of the law of Moses was not required of them. The dispute had been resolved, so the work of teaching and preaching in Antioch could continue unimpeded.

Acts 15:36–41

The discordant separation of Paul and Barnabas is indicated by a very strong word in Greek (their disagreement was so sharp). It was an honest disagreement between two godly men about whether John Mark (Barnabas's cousin, [Col 4:10](#)) should be given a second chance to accompany them on a

mission journey after he had deserted them in Pamphylia (see [Acts 13:13](#)). The rift between Paul and John Mark was eventually healed ([2 Tim 4:11](#)).

Acts 15:40–41

Following his disagreement with Barnabas over John Mark, Paul chose Silas as his partner for a second missionary journey through Syria and Cilicia. The two men traveled overland to visit Derbe and Lystra, explaining the decision of the Jerusalem council and strengthening believers in their faith.

Acts 16:1–3

Paul returned to churches that he and Barnabas had established on their previous journey.

Acts 16:3

Paul had Timothy circumcised to enhance Timothy's acceptance and effectiveness as a Jew in Jewish circles (contrast Titus, who was a full Gentile, [Gal 2:3](#)). Elsewhere Paul clarified that it makes no difference to God whether one is circumcised or not circumcised ([Rom 2:25–29](#); [Gal 5:6](#); [6:15](#)). Paul was prepared to use any legitimate means to communicate the Good News ([1 Cor 9:20–21](#)) to various audiences.

Acts 16:4–5

Paul and Silas faithfully communicated the decisions of the Jerusalem council. The wisdom of the decision was indicated as the churches were strengthened in their faith and grew larger every day (cp. [2:41](#); [4:4](#); [5:14](#); [6:1](#); [9:31](#); [21:20](#)).

Acts 16:6–10

God directed the missionaries' travels: The Holy Spirit had prevented them from proceeding westward into the province of Asia, the Spirit of Jesus did not allow them to go north to Bithynia, and then Paul had a vision calling them to go northwest over the Aegean Sea to Macedonia. God's Spirit guided his servants in Acts in a variety of ways, including divine visions (see also [9:10](#); [10:9–16](#); [22:18](#)), direct intuition (cp. [8:29, 39](#); [10:19](#); [20:22](#)), counsel with other believers (cp. [15:29](#)), guidance through prayer ([13:2, 4](#)), insight through Scripture ([28:25–27](#)), and prophecy ([11:28](#)). Guidance by the indwelling Holy Spirit helped them to accomplish their mission to be Christ's witnesses ([1:8](#); see also [4:8, 31](#); [11:24](#); [13:9](#)).

Acts 16:8

Troas, a major port on the Aegean Sea, was one of the more significant cities in the Roman Empire. Paul's strategy was often to visit principal places such as Troas, Athens, Corinth, and Ephesus. When the Christian faith had been planted

in major centers, local Christian workers could carry it into outlying areas (e.g., Epaphras took the message from Ephesus to Colosse, [Col 1:7](#); [4:12–13](#)).

Acts 16:9–10

a vision: See “Visions” Theme Note.

Acts 16:10

we: The most natural interpretation of the shift from “they” to “we” is that Luke accompanied Paul from Troas to Philippi ([16:10–17](#)). Later Luke joined Paul again at Philippi and sailed with him to Troas, then to Miletus ([20:5–15](#)), then from Miletus to Jerusalem ([21:1–18](#)). After Paul’s two-year imprisonment in Caesarea, Luke traveled with him to Rome ([27:1–28:16](#)).

Acts 16:11

Samothrace is a small mountainous island lying west-northwest of the Hellespont about twenty miles (32 km) from the coast of Thrace. • Neapolis (modern Kavala) was the seaport for Philippi and the eastern terminus of the famous *Via Egnatia* (the Egnatian Way), which ran from Rome to Asia.

Acts 16:12

At Philippi, about ten miles (17 km) inland from Neapolis, Paul began his missionary labors in Europe.

Acts 16:13

The Jewish community at Philippi was too small to have a synagogue, which required ten adult males. Instead, Jews met for prayer in an open space by the Gangites (now called Angista) River that afforded privacy, quiet, and water for Jewish purification rites.

Acts 16:13–36

Luke gives his readers cameos of three lives touched by the Good News in Philippi: a wealthy woman ([16:14–15](#)), an exploited slave girl ([16:16–21](#)), and a middle-class officer ([16:23–36](#)).

Acts 16:14–15

The first person changed by Christ in Philippi was Lydia, a successful businesswoman from Thyatira (modern Akhisar), a city of western Asia Minor famous for its woolen fabrics, weavers, and linens. Lydia responded to the message and she and her household were baptized (cp. [16:32–33](#)). • One of Lydia’s first acts as a true believer in the Lord was to extend hospitality to the visiting missionaries. Hospitality is an important Christian virtue ([Matt 25:31–46](#); [Rom 12:13](#); [16:23](#); [1 Tim 3:2](#); [Titus 1:8](#); [Heb 13:2](#); [1 Pet 4:9](#); [3 Jn 1:5–8](#); cp. [Gen 18:1–8](#); [19:1–3](#); [24:23–33](#)).

Acts 16:16–18

The second portrait of a changed life in Philippi is of a slave girl who had a spirit that enabled her to tell the future. • Even though the demon within her was stating the truth, Paul, like Jesus, did not permit it to proclaim the Christian message (cp. [Mark 1:25, 34](#); [3:11–12](#); [Luke 4:35, 41](#)). The Lord had commanded that the gospel be proclaimed by his disciples, not by opponents ([Acts 1:8](#); [9:15](#); [26:15–18](#); [Matt 28:18–20](#); [Luke 24:46–49](#); [John 20:21](#); see [Acts 22:15](#)).

Acts 16:19–21

As in the ministry of Jesus, sometimes the Good News threatened established commercial interests (see also [19:25–27](#); [Mark 5:1–20](#)). The slave girl’s exploiters viciously attacked the missionaries and dragged them before the authorities as criminals, blamed them for fomenting a disturbance, resorted to racial bias (these Jews), and appealed to the Philippians’ pride (us Romans; the Philippians prided themselves on being Roman citizens of a Roman colony). • customs that are illegal: By law, Jews were not permitted to make converts of Romans.

Acts 16:22–24

All reasonable security measures were taken to ensure that Paul and Silas didn’t escape after they had been stripped and beaten with wooden rods (see [22:24–26](#); [2 Cor 6:5](#); [11:23–25](#)). As at Christ’s tomb ([Matt 27:65](#)), however, human effort did not prevent divine intervention.

Acts 16:25

Paul and Silas, like the persecuted apostles in Jerusalem, were joyful, “rejoicing that God had counted them worthy to suffer disgrace for the name of Jesus” ([5:41](#)).

Acts 16:26

The massive earthquake is reminiscent of the great earthquake at Jesus’ resurrection ([Matt 28:2–3](#)).

Acts 16:27

The Roman jailer clearly knew that his life could be forfeited if the prisoners for whom he was responsible escaped. This was standard practice ([12:19](#); [27:42](#); cp. *Code of Justinian* 9.4.4).

Acts 16:27–36

Luke’s third portrait in Philippi is of the Philippian jailer who, shaken by what had happened, responded in faith when challenged to accept the Lord Jesus and be saved. He was baptized with his household and rejoiced in his newfound faith as he reached out with hospitality to the preachers.

Acts 16:29–30

Paul and Silas had impressed the jailer with their cheerful faith (16:25), their composure in crisis, and their concern for his well-being (16:28). Whatever the jailer's previous understanding of Paul's message, God touched his heart, and he cried out for divine help.

Acts 16:31–34

Paul and Silas directed the jailer to a faith in Christ that brings blessing both to him and to his family. The whole household received Christian instruction, and their response was expressed in baptism and the offering of hospitality to Paul and Silas.

Acts 16:37–39

Paul and Silas were both Roman citizens, so the beating and imprisonment (16:22–24) had been illegal. After the city officials learned of this, they were justifiably alarmed because they had committed a crime against Rome. • Let them come themselves to release us: Paul made use of his rights as a Roman citizen in order to clear his name and ensure that no disrepute would attach to the Christian message or those who accepted it. Luke intended to show that Christianity should enjoy the same status as Judaism in the Roman Empire as a permitted religion—the Christian faith was compatible with the life of a Roman citizen. Accordingly, it was important to note that Paul made use of his rights as a Roman citizen (cp. 22:25–27) and was ready to use the privileges of citizenship to advance the cause of Christ in a hostile world.

Acts 16:40

This meeting in the home of Lydia bolstered the spirits of the Philippian Christians who had to deal with the fallout from the missionaries' work there.

Acts 17:1–3

Amphipolis was a Roman military post located on the Egnatian Way in the northeastern part of Macedonia. • Apollonia, named after the Greek god Apollo, was also situated on the Egnatian Way. • Thessalonica offered a starting point for ministry because it had a Jewish synagogue (see study note on 9:2). Paul was able to preach for three consecutive Sabbaths, explaining the Scriptures and showing their fulfillment in Jesus.

Acts 17:1–9

After traveling through Macedonia to Thessalonica, Paul preached to the Jews first (Rom 1:16) in the synagogue. Here, as elsewhere, there was a mixed response.

Acts 17:4

God-fearing Greek men: See study note on 10:2. • Luke regularly draws attention to women who joined the Christian movement (17:4, 12, 34; see also 5:14; 8:12; 16:13–15, 31–34; 18:26; 21:9).

Acts 17:5–7

Once again, the enemies of the Christian faith saw it as a disruptive threat (cp. 16:19–21). Ironically, they gathered some troublemakers and then accused Paul and Silas of causing trouble by disturbing the peace and committing treason against Caesar—serious charges of threatening the stability of the empire (cp. Luke 23:2).

Acts 17:8–9

The charges did not hold up under scrutiny, so the officials released Jason and the other believers after they posted bond. Christianity, Luke contended, was politically harmless to the Roman Empire and should therefore be recognized as a permitted religion and not subjected to political attack.

Acts 17:10–12

In light of the strong opposition in Thessalonica, the believers sent Paul and Silas to Berea, located about fifty miles (80.5 km) west of Thessalonica. There the missionaries had a better reception than in Thessalonica. Many Jews came to faith, as well as many of the prominent Greek women and men. The Bereans were exemplary in their attitude, for they were open-minded and eager to learn, good listeners, diligent Bible students, and thoughtful people. Their resulting faith had a strong foundation.

Acts 17:13–15

Paul acknowledged the determination and persistence of this persecution when he wrote to the Thessalonians (1 Thes 2:14–16).

Acts 17:16–17

Athens, like Alexandria and Tarsus, prided itself on its intellectual sophistication in examining ideas and considering the different philosophies that were current at the time.

Acts 17:16–34

In this chapter, we see Paul presented as a model witness for Christ, engaging the thinkers of his day and challenging them with the Christian message. Paul quoted writers his audience would be familiar with and showed the relevance of the gospel by dialoguing with them, critiquing their assumptions, and offering Jesus as a constructive alternative (see Col 1:28). Paul reminded these proud intellectuals that there is a living God to whom all human beings are answer-

able; that they will be judged by him through Jesus, whom God raised from the dead; and that they should therefore repent and put their faith in Jesus.

Acts 17:18

Epicurean . . . philosophers: Epicureanism was a popular school of Greek philosophy, founded by Epicurus (341–270 BC). Epicureans believed that the principal aim of life was to secure happiness. They thought of pleasure not in terms of sensual indulgence, as their critics charged, but in terms of tranquility. Their contemporaries often called them atheists; in their view, there were no gods to fear, and death simply marked the end of human existence. They sought their security in organized communities where they could live in contentment apart from society. • Stoic philosophers: Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium (335–263 BC) and became the most influential philosophy in the Greco-Roman world. It viewed the universe as permeated by Reason (sometimes referred to as God or Providence). Stoicism saw divine Reason as expressed in human reason and held that as humans made progress, they could advance from ignorance (the source of vice) to true knowledge (the source of virtue). They developed extensive lists of virtues and vices and produced detailed household codes to guide family behavior. Paul's teaching resembles that of the Stoics in his use of household codes and lists of virtues and vices ([Gal 5:19–23](#); [Eph 5:22–33](#); [Col 3:18–4:1](#); [1 Tim 3:1–13](#); [5:1–6:1](#)). However, Paul's message of Good News—focusing on the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ—was strange and foreign to these Greek philosophers. • The air of superiority with which they addressed Paul as this babblers indicates their arrogance.

Acts 17:22–31

Paul's remarkable sermon in Athens reveals his versatility in preaching the Good News ([Rom 11:14](#); [1 Cor 9:19–23](#); [10:33](#); cp. [Acts 16:3](#); [17:2–3](#); [21:20–26](#)). While Paul's Greek audience did not know the Scriptures or have a tradition of monotheism as the Jews did, they did have a rich intellectual heritage. So Paul established a point of contact on the basis of an Athenian inscription to an Unknown God. He then explained God's nature as the Creator ([17:22–29](#)), followed by God's purpose as the Redeemer ([17:30–31](#)). • As he did elsewhere in his own writings (see [1 Cor 15:33](#); [Titus 1:12](#)), Paul made use of the Greek poets. There are several points of connection in this sermon with the *Hymn to Zeus* by Cleanthes (about 315–240 BC). Paul was probably quoting Epimenides, who had declared about God, "In him we live and move and exist" (Epimenides, *Cretica*, about 600 BC). Paul also cited Aratus, a Stoic poet from Cilicia (about 315–240 BC), who had commented, "We are his offspring" (Aratus, *Phaenomena* 5). These allusions to their own poets established connections with his audience.

Paul was then able to present the singular nature of God ([Acts 17:29](#)), and he stressed the coming judgment through Jesus Christ, whom God had raised from the dead. This message, while touching on Greek culture and philosophy, had a clear focus on Christ that presented the challenge of Christ to a cultured and intellectual but idolatrous people.

Acts 17:30

The idea of people's ignorance is carefully discussed both in the Old Testament law ([Lev 4:2, 22, 27](#); [5:15, 17](#); [Num 15:25, 27](#)) and in the New Testament ([Eph 4:18](#); [1 Pet 1:14](#); [2:15](#); [2 Pet 3:5, 8](#)). Paul was particularly fervent about combating ignorance (see [Rom 10:13–15](#); [11:25](#); [1 Cor 10:1](#); [12:1](#); [2 Cor 1:8](#); [1 Thes 4:13](#)). The message of Good News overcomes ignorance and summons all who hear it to repent of their sins and turn to God (see [Acts 2:38](#)).

Acts 17:32

The Athenians listened carefully until Paul spoke of the resurrection of the dead ([17:31](#)); at that point some laughed or mocked, for the notion of resurrection was foolish to Greek ears (see [1 Cor 15:12–19](#)). Similarly, the Jews in Jerusalem later listened carefully to Paul until he mentioned God's acceptance of the Gentiles ([Acts 22:22](#)). These are examples of how the message of Good News can offend people because of their prejudices (see [1 Cor 1:20–25](#)).

Acts 17:34

some joined him and became believers: Paul's sermon was not without positive response. Two prominent converts are mentioned: Dionysius and Damaris. Luke often placed a man and a woman in juxtaposition (e.g., [5:1–11](#); [17:4, 12](#); [Luke 14:1–6](#); [15:3–10](#)). • Dionysius was a member of the council of the Areopagus, the highest governing body of Athens.

Acts 18:1

In Roman times, Greek political power in Achaia resided in Corinth, a prominent city-state and major commercial city. Corinth was notorious for its prostitution, immorality, and drunkenness (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, "Setting"). Paul invested much time and effort establishing a Christian community in Corinth (see study note on Acts 16:8).

Acts 18:1–17

Paul spent eighteen fruitful months preaching and teaching in Corinth, first in the synagogue and then next door in the house of Titius Justus ([18:1–11](#)). Then, in court, Paul won a significant victory over his enemies ([18:12–17](#)).

Acts 18:2–3

The edict of Claudius Caesar that had deported all Jews from Rome around AD 49 is mentioned by the Roman historian Suetonius (*Life of Claudius* 25). • Aquila and Priscilla became an outstanding husband-and-wife team in the early church. They earned their living as tentmakers, as did Paul, who probably lived and worked with them during his year and a half in Corinth (18:11; see Rom 16:3–4; 1 Cor 16:19). • just as he was: Paul would have been trained as a tentmaker as a young man. It was Jewish custom to provide sons with a manual trade, including young men who intended to become rabbis or other professionals.

Acts 18:4–6

Once again Paul followed his custom of preaching to the Jews first, and then reaching out to Gentiles after he met with rejection and opposition (13:42–49; see 3:25–26; 26:20; Rom 1:16; 2:10; 3:29, 30; 4:9–12). • Paul probably wrote his letters to the Thessalonian Christians after Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia with a report of how things were going there (see 1 Thes 3:6; 2 Thessalonians Book Introduction, “Setting”).

Acts 18:7

Titus Justus (“Titus the Just”) was a Gentile who worshiped God (a “God-fearer”; see study note on 10:2). Because Titus was a common Roman name, *Justus* differentiates him from the better-known Titus, Paul’s co-worker (2 Cor 2:13; 7:6, 13; 8:6, 16, 23; Titus).

Acts 18:9–10

Paul had experienced real opposition in Corinth (18:6) and apparently was afraid of being attacked again, so the divine message was a comfort to him (cp. 23:11; Ps 34:4, 7, 19; Matt 28:20), encouraging him to persist in his public ministry and promising God’s protection (cp. Ps 91:11; 2 Tim 4:17).

Acts 18:12–13

The governor of Achaia, Junio Gallio, was the older brother of the Roman philosopher Seneca (Seneca was a tutor to Emperor Nero). An inscription indicating that he was governor around AD 51–52 helps to date Paul’s visit in Corinth to about that time.

Acts 18:14–17

Gallio’s ruling indicated that the charges against Paul were unjustified. The Roman government had nothing to fear from acknowledging Christianity as a legal religion.

Acts 18:17

It is most likely that the Greeks beat Sosthenes to express their hostility to the Jews; it is possible that the Jews attacked their own synagogue leader because he was unsuccessful in pleading their case. Sosthenes may be the same man Paul later mentions as “our brother” (1 Cor 1:1), but it is uncertain, as the name was fairly common.

Acts 18:18

Cenchrea was a seaport located on the Aegean Sea, roughly five miles (8 km) east of Corinth. It was here that Paul shaved his head according to Jewish custom to mark the completion of a temporary Nazirite vow (cp. 21:23–24; see Num 6:1–21; Judg 13:4–7; 16:1; Amos 2:11–12; Luke 1:15).

Acts 18:19–23

Paul made a quick stop at Ephesus, the most important city in the Roman province of Asia. There he left the others behind, including Priscilla and Aquila (18:26). He sailed to Judea, landing at Caesarea, the headquarters of the Roman forces of occupation. After a visit to the church at Jerusalem, Paul returned to Antioch, the church that had originally commissioned him. This marked the end of his second missionary journey. In Antioch, he spent a rewarding time of reporting what God had done through him and his colleagues, sharing the excitement and challenges of their work with the home church. Then after . . . some time, Paul began his third missionary journey. He went by land rather than by sea, traveling through Galatia and Phrygia and revisiting believers whom he had led to faith in Christ on his previous trips. It was important to him that these young converts not be left to founder and shipwreck their faith (see Eph 6:10–20; 1 Tim 1:18–20; 2 Tim 1:15; 4:10).

Acts 18:21

“I will come back later”: Paul later spent significant time in Ephesus during his third missionary journey (19:1–20:1; see 19:8, 10).

Acts 18:23

Paul wanted to keep in touch with earlier converts and strengthen their faith.

Acts 18:23–19:41

This section describes Paul’s third missionary journey (about AD 53–57). Paul revisited Galatia and Phrygia, strengthening the disciples (18:23). He then traveled to Ephesus (19:1), where he remained for over two years (19:8–10).

Acts 18:24–26

Alexandria, the second-largest city in the Roman Empire, was famous for its rhetorical tradition and the philosophical work of Philo. Apollos was an eloquent speaker with an excellent knowledge of the Scriptures (the Old Testament). His knowledge about Jesus and the Holy Spirit was inadequate, though. He did not understand that believers could experience and enjoy the power of the Holy Spirit as a present energizing reality. Fortunately, Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and corrected his spiritual understanding.

Acts 19:1–7

Paul traveled to Ephesus after Apollos had left. Subsequently, Apollos returned to Ephesus while Paul was still working there (1 Cor 16:12). The two men had different personalities, gifts, and roles, but God worked through both of them. • Some believers in Ephesus still had an inadequate understanding of the Christian faith (cp. Acts 18:26) and did not receive the Holy Spirit when they believed. They had accepted John’s baptism, which called for repentance from sin, but had not received Christian baptism, which included the gift of the Holy Spirit. When Paul had instructed them further, they were able to receive Christian baptism (19:5) and the Holy Spirit (19:6).

Acts 19:6

When Paul laid his hands on them they received the Holy Spirit, spoke in other tongues and prophesied, thereby experiencing the same filling with God’s power and presence that the disciples had received on the day of Pentecost (2:4, 11).

Acts 19:10

Paul probably wrote 1 Corinthians during this time (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, “Date and Occasion of Writing”).

Acts 19:11–12

Paul, like other Christian evangelists (3:1–11; 4:22; 5:12–16; 6:8; 8:6–7, 13; 9:33–42), performed unusual miracles. • evil spirits were expelled: As Jesus and Peter had done (cp. 5:16; Mark 1:21–34; Luke 4:31–37).

Acts 19:13–16

Paul’s effectiveness is contrasted with the impotence of the traveling Jewish exorcists, who used the name of Jesus as though it were magical but did not have a relationship with him or the indwelling power of the Holy Spirit (cp. Matt 12:27; Mark 9:38–39; Luke 9:49–50; 11:19).

Acts 19:17–19

The contrast between Paul and the Jewish exorcists was not lost on the people of Ephesus, Jews and Greeks alike. The resulting fear caused the inhabitants to honor and respect the name of the Lord Jesus. It led many to confess and forsake their sinful practices, including sorcery.

Acts 19:20

Luke’s summary of the success of the Good News in Ephesus is short but pungent (cp. 2:43–47; 5:14; 6:7; 9:31; 12:24; 16:5; see Rom 1:16). When the Christian faith overcame problems of internal dissension, idolatry, and pagan practices, it spread widely and grew rapidly.

Acts 19:21–22

felt compelled by the Spirit: No doubt Paul was troubled by what he had heard about the situation in Corinth (see 1 Corinthians Book Introduction). Instead of going immediately himself, he sent . . . Timothy, who was carrying a letter, 1 Corinthians, from Paul to the Corinthians (1 Cor 4:17; 16:10–11). Paul himself did go over to Macedonia and Achaia not long afterward (Acts 20:1–3). • “I must go on to Rome!”: Perhaps compelled by his proven strategy (see study note on 16:8), Paul wanted to proclaim the Good News in the most significant city in the world.

Acts 19:23

the Way: See study note on 9:2.

Acts 19:23–41

The patron deity of Ephesus was the Greek goddess Artemis. Her birthplace was believed to be Ephesus, so Ephesus was the official guardian of the temple. Twice annually, elaborate festivals were held in her honor with athletic, musical, and theatrical celebrations that included singing Great is Artemis of the Ephesians! The temple of Artemis at Ephesus was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. Conversions to Christianity clearly damaged the worship of Artemis and the associated economic activity, but it became clear that Paul and his associates had committed no crime.

Acts 19:24

Silver coins and shrines carrying the image of Artemis were minted in Ephesus; statuettes of the goddess were used in civic processions and are still sold there today.

Acts 19:24–34

Demetrius, a silversmith whose business was threatened by Paul’s proclaiming faith in one God, whipped up a major riot against him.

Acts 19:27

all around the world: The ancient geographer Strabo reports that temples dedicated to Artemis existed in cities from Asia Minor (now Turkey) to what is now France and Spain (Strabo, *Geography* 3.4.8; 4.1.4).

Acts 19:29

Archaeologists have excavated the amphitheater where the whole city assembled; it held 24,000 people.

Acts 19:31

Some of the officials of the province (Greek Asiarchai, “rulers of Asia”): The “Asiarchs” were the appointed leaders in the Roman province of Asia. They served as civic benefactors and usually championed the emperor cult. Some of these officials in high places were friends of Paul—Luke highlights that Christianity was attractive to people of high standing in society.

Acts 19:35

The tradition that the image (statue) of Artemis had fallen from heaven might point to its having been carved from a meteor.

Acts 19:35–41

The demonstration was finally quelled only when the mayor intervened and dismissed the assembly to prevent the city from being charged by the Roman government with rioting. This story demonstrates that Christians in the Roman world were entitled to legal due process.

Acts 20:1–2

Paul traveled to Macedonia, where he encouraged the believers in all the towns, including Thessalonica, Philippi, and Berea. He also continued to gather the offering for the needy in Jerusalem (see [Rom 15:25–28](#); [2 Cor 8:1–9:15](#)). Titus met Paul in Macedonia with a report from Corinth, which prompted Paul to write 2 Corinthians and send Titus back carrying it ([2 Cor 7:5–7](#); [8:6](#)).

Acts 20:2–3

From Macedonia, Paul traveled down to Greece—i.e., Corinth in the province of Achaia (see study note on 18:1)—where he stayed for three months (cp. [2 Cor 13:1](#)). Paul probably wrote his letter to the Romans during this time (see Romans Book Introduction, “Date, Place, and Occasion of Writing”). • a plot . . . against his life: Cp. [Acts 9:23–25, 28–30](#); [23:12–35](#); [25:3](#).

Acts 20:4

Paul’s traveling companions were disciples from Berea, Thessalonica, Derbe, and Asia, whom he was mentoring and equipping to lead (cp. [2 Tim 2:2](#)).

Acts 20:5–15

This is another of the “we” passages in Acts (see study note on 16:10). Luke apparently rejoined Paul at Philippi, where Luke had remained several years earlier, and journeyed with Paul to Jerusalem ([21:1–18](#)).

Acts 20:7–12

On the first day of the week the early church commemorated Jesus’ resurrection (see [Mark 16:9](#); cp. [John 20:19](#); [Rev 1:10](#)). • This was Paul’s last visit to Troas, which included gathering to share in the Lord’s Supper. This meal probably included both communion and a common meal (cp. [Acts 2:42, 46](#); [Jude 1:12](#)). • The remarkable feature of this gathering was the understated miraculous restoration of Eutychus, the young man who fell asleep on a windowsill and dropped three stories to his death (cp. [Acts 9:36–41](#)).

Acts 20:13–15

Assos was a key city in Mysia on the east coast of the Aegean Sea. • Mitylene was the most strategic city on the island of Lesbos. • The island of Samos was of major importance on the trade routes from Asia Minor to the west and from the Aegean Sea to Egypt.

Acts 20:16

The Festival of Pentecost was one of the three Jewish pilgrimage festivals (see study note on 2:1–4).

Acts 20:17

Miletus was a major port on the western coast of Asia Minor at the mouth of the Meander River. It provided a place for Paul to meet briefly with the elders of Ephesus on his way to Jerusalem.

Acts 20:18–38

Paul’s address to the elders of the church of Ephesus is a testimony regarding his life and ministry in Ephesus, calling for similar dedication from the leaders who would carry on the ministry. The sermon highlights Paul’s integrity and pastoral care ([20:18–21, 26, 31](#)), speaks about the future ([20:22–23, 25, 29–30](#)), warns against false teachers ([20:29–30](#)), and exhorts the elders to be watchful and faithful ([20:28, 31](#)). Paul modeled sacrificial, conscientious, servant leadership.

Acts 20:23

the Holy Spirit tells me: See, e.g., [21:10–12](#).

Acts 20:26

I have been faithful. If anyone suffers eternal death, it's not my fault: Cp. [Ezek 3:16–21](#).

Acts 20:28

Paul refers to the church as God's people and God's flock (cp. [1 Pet 2:25](#); [5:2](#), 4). Elsewhere the church is called *the body of Christ* ([1 Cor 12:27](#); [Eph 1:23](#); [4:12](#); [Col 1:24](#)); the *bride of Christ* ([2 Cor 11:2](#); [Rev 19:7](#); see [Eph 5:25–32](#)); *the temple of the living God* ([1 Cor 3:16](#); [2 Cor 6:16](#)); *a chosen people, royal priests, a holy nation, God's very own possession* ([1 Pet 2:9](#)); and *God's field, God's building* ([1 Cor 3:9](#)). • Paul expected the leaders to feed and shepherd the church over which the Holy Spirit had appointed them as leaders (see [1 Tim 3:1–7](#); [Titus 1:5–7](#); [1 Pet 5:1–4](#); cp. [Acts 6:2–4](#)).

Acts 20:29–30

vicious wolves: Paul's prophecy did in fact happen, prompting him to write to Timothy in Ephesus some five years later (see [1 Tim 1:3–7](#), [19–20](#); [4:1–5](#); see also [Matt 7:15](#); [10:16](#); [Mark 13:22](#); [Luke 10:3](#); [2 Pet 2:1–22](#); [3:3](#)).

Acts 20:35

'It is more blessed to give than to receive': This saying of Jesus is not recorded in the Gospels.

Acts 20:38

The poignancy of the occasion was heightened by awareness that they would never see him again ([20:25](#)).

Acts 21:1

Cos was an island in the Aegean Sea with a major trade port. • Rhodes is a large Aegean island that featured the Colossus, a huge statue 100 feet (30 meters) tall that once stood at the entrance to the city. In Paul's time, the statue lay where it had fallen during an earthquake over 200 years earlier; it would not be removed for another 600 years. • Patara was the major port of Lycia, located on the coast opposite Rhodes.

Acts 21:1–18

This "we" passage (see study notes on [16:10](#); [20:5–15](#)) covers Paul's journey from Miletus to Jerusalem at the close of the third missionary journey.

Acts 21:2–3

Tyre was an important port in Phoenicia with a maritime empire of far-flung commercial interests (see [Isa 23](#); [Jer 25:15–38](#); [47](#); [Zech 9](#); [Matt 15:21–28](#); [Mark 7:24–31](#)).

Acts 21:4–6

The local believers at Tyre gave Paul a touching farewell that reveals deep Christian fellowship. • prophesied through the Holy Spirit that Paul should not go on to Jerusalem: The believers at Tyre clearly foresaw the danger in Paul's visiting Jerusalem and out of brotherly concern tried to dissuade him. Paul willingly accepted the risks in order to fulfill his apostolic mandate (cp. [Phil 3:7–10](#)). See also study note on [Acts 21:11–14](#).

Acts 21:7

Paul visited Ptolemais, an important city on the coast of the Mediterranean, as he made his way from Tyre to Caesarea.

Acts 21:8

Philip had the title of Evangelist due to his evangelistic activity ([8:4–40](#); cp. [Eph 4:11](#); [2 Tim 4:5](#)).

Acts 21:9

Philip's daughters' gift of prophecy demonstrated the fulfillment of Joel's prophecy, as Peter had preached at Pentecost ([2:17–21](#); [Joel 2:28–32](#)).

Acts 21:10

Luke juxtaposes female prophets ([21:9](#)) with a male prophet (see study note on [17:34](#)). Agabus, like the Old Testament prophets, used symbolic actions to proclaim his message (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note).

Acts 21:11–14

Despite Agabus's prediction of suffering and the believers' begging Paul not to go to Jerusalem, Paul was resolutely ready even to die for the sake of the Lord Jesus. Luke stresses Paul's courage, determination, and heroism as a Christian missionary who would let nothing interfere with his mission. See study note on [21:4–6](#).

Acts 21:18–19

It was important for James and all the elders of the Jerusalem church to hear of Paul's successful mission among the Gentiles and for the mother church to continue to endorse this effort ([21:20](#); see [15:7–21](#)). Paul's report communicated that God had accomplished his purposes among the Gentiles through Paul's ministry.

Acts 21:20–25

The Jerusalem church leaders urged Paul to strengthen his credibility by demonstrating that he was not teaching Jews to turn their backs on the laws of Moses. At the same time, no attempt was made to force Jewish rules on Gentile converts—those terms had been set previously (15:22–29) and were simply to be honored.

Acts 21:26–36

The concerns of the Christian leaders (21:20–25) were evidently well based, for when their vows were almost completed, some Jews from the province of Asia raised a mob against Paul with false charges. They were intent on killing Paul, but the Roman commander rescued him.

Acts 21:28–29

Gentiles: It was a crime punishable by death to bring any non-Jew into the Temple precincts beyond the Court of the Gentiles (see also Josephus, *War* 5.5.2; 6.2.4). The Jews assumed that Paul had violated this sacred law by bringing Trophimus, a Gentile from Ephesus (see also Acts 20:4; 2 Tim 4:20), into the forbidden area.

Acts 21:30

This supposed desecration of the Temple aroused the fury of the Jewish populace. The Temple . . . gates were closed because they thought the Temple had been defiled by a Gentile.

Acts 21:31

commander: Or *tribune*, a Roman officer who commanded 1,000 men.

Acts 21:34

The fortress of Antonia, a large military garrison built by Herod the Great on the northwest corner of the Temple Mount, accommodated the Roman cohort that was stationed there to keep the peace.

Acts 21:37–40

The commander had mistaken Paul for an Egyptian false messiah who had planned to seize power from the Romans around AD 54 (roughly three years earlier; see Josephus, *War* 2.13.5). Paul corrected the mistake, gained permission to speak to the people, and addressed the crowd in Aramaic, the common language of Judea. He gave a strong statement of his faith in Jesus as the Messiah (Acts 22:1–21).

Acts 22:1–21

Paul's premier defense of his life and faith before his own people in Jerusalem illustrates his flexibility as a missionary,

just as his speech to the Greek philosophers in Athens had done (17:22–31; see 1 Cor 9:20–23). Paul begins by recognizing his kinship with his people, explaining his Jewish background and training under the noted rabbi Gamaliel the Elder and describing his zealous desire to honor God in everything, which they shared (Acts 22:1–3). Paul then describes his persecution of Christians (22:4–5), the revelation of Jesus to him on the way to Damascus (22:6–10), and his conversion (22:11–16). Paul ends his speech by describing his conversation with the Lord in the Temple. The Lord had predicted the Jews' rejection of the message and had sent Paul to the Gentiles (22:17–21).

Acts 22:3

under Gamaliel: See study note on 5:34.

Acts 22:12–16

Ananias: See study note on 9:17.

Acts 22:14

the Righteous One: See also 3:14; 7:52; 1 Jn 2:1. Righteousness was one of the Messiah's characteristics (see Isa 32:1; 53:11).

Acts 22:16

be baptized. Have your sins washed away: See "Baptism" Theme Note.

Acts 22:17–22

While Paul was praying in the Temple, he saw a vision of Jesus telling him that the people of Jerusalem would not accept his testimony. The Lord then sent him to the Gentiles. The crowd's response to this report (22:22–23) proved the point.

Acts 22:23

The crowd's yelling, throwing off their coats, and tossing handfuls of dust into the air were probably ritual responses to perceived blasphemy. They opposed and tried to thwart Paul's words that suggested the inclusion of Gentiles (22:21). Cp. Luke 4:16–30.

Acts 22:25–29

Paul claimed his status as a Roman citizen at this critical time when he was about to be tortured to make him confess his supposed crime. Roman citizenship was a valuable asset, and claiming it falsely was a capital offense. Its principal benefits were the prohibition of scourging and the right to appeal to the emperor (25:11). The commander was frightened at having nearly violated Roman law (cp. 16:35–39).

Acts 22:28

it cost me plenty! During the early part of the reign of Emperor Claudius (AD 41–54), Roman citizenship could be purchased, but it was expensive.

Acts 23:1

In addressing the high council, Paul insisted on his personal integrity before God—he had not violated God’s law or done the things they accused him of doing.

Acts 23:2

Ananias was the Jewish high priest from AD 47 to 58. • slap him: He apparently assumed that Paul was lying and tried to intimidate him.

Acts 23:3

you corrupt hypocrite: Cp. [Ezek 13:10–17](#); [Matt 23:27](#).

Acts 23:5

Why Paul did not recognize the high priest is not known. • Paul replied by quoting [Exod 22:28](#), acknowledging the respect to which the high priest was entitled by virtue of his office.

Acts 23:6

Paul focused on the key issue in his trial, the hope of resurrection from the dead. His preaching was simply the outworking of that hope and the fact of Jesus’ resurrection, but the message was unacceptable to both groups of Jews because of its implications. Pharisees could not abide the inclusion of the Gentiles apart from circumcision and keeping the law of Moses (cp. [15:5](#)), but that was what the resurrection of Jesus and the outpouring of the Spirit had provided ([Acts 2:39](#); [10:34–48](#)). Sadducees could not stand the proclamation of the resurrection at all (cp. [4:1–2](#)).

Acts 23:7–10

Paul’s statement ([23:6](#)) divided the council, with the Pharisees taking Paul’s side against the Sadducees. The resulting uproar was so great that the commander rescued Paul and took him back into the fortress of Antonia.

Acts 23:11

At this critical juncture, Jesus encouraged Paul to continue as his faithful witness by assuring him that he would go to Rome (see [19:21](#)).

Acts 23:12–15

The plan to kill Paul was desperate, as a group of . . . more than forty took an oath not to eat or drink until they

had killed Paul (cp. [1 Sam 14:24–46](#); [Matt 14:6–11](#); see also [Deut 23:21–23](#); [Matt 5:33–37](#); [Jas 5:12](#)).

Acts 23:16–22

Paul’s nephew thwarted the murderous plot by reporting it to one of the Roman officers.

Acts 23:23–35

A mounted escort took Paul safely to the Roman Governor Felix in Caesarea, the Roman headquarters for Judea. There Paul would have greater protection than in Jerusalem. The military operation was executed that night with secret efficiency and maximum security ([23:31](#)).

Acts 23:24

Antonius Felix was procurator (Governor) of Judea about AD 52–59, with responsibility for both military and civil affairs. Felix had a bad reputation (see [24:24–27](#)) and was eventually recalled to Rome by Nero.

Acts 23:26–30

The letter of Claudius Lysias to Governor Felix is a typical Hellenistic letter, naming the writer and the person addressed, offering a greeting, and stating the business at hand (though there is no parting word of farewell; see study note on [15:29](#)). It summarizes the events that preceded it and explains the action taken; it also suggests that the commander has followed proper Roman judicial procedure. • The title his Excellency was often applied to persons of high social, political, or economic status ([Luke 1:3](#)).

Acts 23:31

Antipatris, a city rebuilt by Herod the Great in 9 BC on the Plain of Sharon, was a convenient military control point between Jerusalem and Caesarea.

Acts 23:35

The governor followed the proper protocol and waited for Paul’s accusers to arrive before granting an official hearing. • Herod’s headquarters was Herod the Great’s palace at Caesarea; it subsequently became the residence of the Roman governors of Judea.

Acts 24:1–4

Tertullus presented the case for the prosecution, beginning with the customary speech of praise intended to attract the attention and sympathy of the governor, followed by the statement of charges ([24:5–8](#)).

Acts 24:1–27

Tertullus presented a legal case against Paul in a Roman court on behalf of the high priest (24:1–9). Then Paul cheerfully made his defense and defended his faith (24:10–21), and the governor adjourned the hearing without a decision and left Paul in prison for two years (24:22–27).

Acts 24:5

Troublemaker (or *agitator*) was a charge of political sedition. A Roman court would have taken this charge very seriously (see 16:21; 17:7; 18:13). Similar accusations were made against Jesus before Pilate (Luke 23:2, 5, 14). • The term cult (or *party*, or *sect*) is used here in a negative sense to put Paul's religion under a pallor of suspicion if not illegality (see also Acts 24:14).

Acts 24:6

trying to desecrate the Temple: See study note on 21:28–29.

Acts 24:10–21

Paul's defense was that (1) he wasn't in Jerusalem long enough to incite a riot; (2) none of his accusers had ever seen him stirring up a riot; and (3) he worshiped in accord with Jewish law and everything written in the prophets.

Acts 24:14

the Way: See study note on 9:2. • Paul emphasized his common ground with his Jewish audience, including his worship, belief in the Jewish law, acceptance of the prophets, and hope in the resurrection (24:14, 15; see 24:21).

Acts 24:15

At the last judgment God will raise both the righteous and the unrighteous. Paul kept this final appointment with God constantly in mind (24:16). The fear of the "coming day of judgment" unnerved Felix in a subsequent conversation with Paul (24:25).

Acts 24:16

Paul stressed that he had acted with a clear conscience (see 20:27, 33; 23:1; 1 Cor 4:4; 2 Cor 1:12; 4:2; see also 2 Tim 1:3). He had not departed from his Jewish heritage (Acts 24:14), and he had no fear of God's judgment (24:15).

Acts 24:17

money to aid my people: See study note on 20:1–2; see also Rom 15:25–29; 1 Cor 16:1–2; 2 Cor 9:1–7. • and to offer sacrifices to God: See Acts 21:23–26.

Acts 24:22

Perhaps Felix delayed his decision hoping that Paul would bribe him (24:26).

Acts 24:23

It was in keeping with the proper treatment of a Roman citizen to give him some freedom and allow his friends to visit him and take care of his needs.

Acts 24:24

Drusilla was the sister of Herod Agrippa II and Bernice (25:13); Drusilla had abandoned her former husband, Azizus the King of Emessa, and married Felix. Drusilla was Jewish, so in forsaking her original husband and marrying Felix she had disregarded God's commands (Exod 20:14; Deut 5:18; cp. Mal 2:16; Mark 10:12). Josephus criticized her for this (*Antiquities* 20.7.1–2). Drusilla and her husband were confronted in their conversation with Paul by the prospect of judgment.

Acts 24:25

Paul's words about righteousness, self-control, and coming divine judgment frightened Felix, who was notably corrupt (24:26–27; see study notes on 23:24; 24:24).

Acts 24:26–27

Felix kept Paul in custody hoping for a bribe. When this failed and his own term ended, he left Paul in prison to gain favor with the Jewish people.

Acts 24:27–25.5

Felix's successor was Porcius Festus, appointed by Nero to be governor of Judea about AD 59–62. Josephus describes Festus as a conscientious, honest administrator who was not able to stem the rising tide of Jewish unrest despite his strong action against the party of the Assassins (Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.8.10; cp. Acts 21:38). He resisted the Jewish leaders' attempt to have Paul's trial moved to Jerusalem, but he was not immune to their pressure (25:9).

Acts 25:7

The serious accusations were probably those raised previously (21:27–28; 24:5–9), but the accusations were unsupported by the evidence (24:10–13).

Acts 25:9

Festus, wanting to please the Jews: The governor would later state his official reason for delaying Paul's trial and asking to move it to Jerusalem (25:17–20). His request was driven by politics, however, not justice.

Acts 25:10–11

Festus's suggestion that Paul be tried in Jerusalem motivated the apostle's appeal to Caesar. Paul was not afraid of death, but he objected to being turned over to a biased court intent on murder, not justice (25:7).

Acts 25:12

Festus granted Paul's appeal. This fulfilled Paul's conviction that he must see Rome (19:21; see also 23:11; 27:24; Rom 1:13–15; 15:22–29).

Acts 25:13–22

Festus discussed Paul's case with Herod Agrippa II (ruled AD 50–100), who had come to Caesarea to make a courtesy call on the new governor.

Acts 25:16

It was a fundamental principle: Roman law did not convict people without a trial. They must be given an opportunity to confront their accusers and defend themselves (cp. 19:38–39). This put Roman judicial procedure in a favorable light for readers of Acts.

Acts 25:17

I didn't delay: In contrast with Felix, his predecessor (24:22–27).

Acts 25:18–20

These verses give Festus's official reasons for his actions; see also 25:9. There were no criminal accusations against Paul; the objections were about their religion and centered on Paul's claim that Jesus . . . is alive.

Acts 25:23–27

Paul's hearing before King Agrippa was accompanied by all the pomp and circumstance appropriate for an official royal visit. The main purpose of the hearing was for Agrippa to advise Festus on what he should write in the appeal to Caesar, for there was no clear charge against Paul, and Festus himself believed Paul had done nothing deserving death.

Acts 26:1–23

In his eloquent defense before King Agrippa, Paul argued that his preaching was completely consistent with the Jewish faith. The defense begins with a courteous acknowledgement of Agrippa's competence to hear the evidence (26:2–3), outlines the nature of Paul's background, Jewish training, and membership in the Pharisees (26:4–5), and explains that the charges against him are merely for believing the fulfillment of Jewish hopes for the resurrection (26:6–8). Paul then tells the story of his conversion from strong oppo-

nent of Christianity (26:9–11) through a vision on the way to Damascus (26:12–18; see 9:1–18). His preaching was nothing more than obeying this divine vision (26:19–20). Even though he encountered violent opposition from his fellow Jews (26:21), God protected him as he taught a message that the Jews should have embraced (26:22–23). This defense is a model for Christians put on trial for their faith (see 9:15; Luke 21:12–15).

Acts 26:12–18

See 9:1–18.

Acts 26:17–18

Throughout his defense in this trial for his life, Paul also clearly set out the conditions for receiving new life in Christ (also in 26:20, 23; see Matt 10:19–20).

Acts 26:22–23

Paul stressed God's protection as he carried out his witness (cp. 3:18; 10:43; Luke 24:25–27, 44–47). Paul then called on his hearers to believe his message, that Jesus is the Messiah who fulfills the promises of the Old Testament (see Luke 24:27, 44).

Acts 26:24

Paul, you are insane: Festus, a Roman, thought all this talk about the prophets and resurrection was crazy (cp. 17:18, 32), and he concluded that Paul must have driven himself mad with too much study.

Acts 26:26

they were not done in a corner: The major events of the Christian faith were historical matters of public record that witnesses could attest as factually true. Agrippa could not invalidate Paul's statements of fact.

Acts 26:27–28

Paul's question put Agrippa in a bind: If he said he believed the prophets, he knew Paul would press home the Christian message; if not, he would offend the devout Jews in his audience. Agrippa knew that Paul wasn't crazy and that Paul's testimony about Jesus was historically sound (26:26). So Agrippa evaded Paul's question and refused to face the claims of Christ, alleging that the statement given by Paul was too brief for him to arrive at a responsible decision.

Acts 26:28

"Do you think you can persuade me to become a Christian so quickly?": This enigmatic remark might have been ironic, incredulous, scoffing, or brushing off Paul's challenge. It also might have been a direct statement of Paul's persuasiveness,

or a direct statement about or genuine question of Paul's intention. It seems best to take Agrippa's reply as deliberately evasive: He didn't want to admit that he believed the prophets (26:27), for Paul had just made a strong case, and the next step would be to believe in Jesus as the promised Messiah to whom the prophets pointed. Agrippa didn't want to take that step. On the other hand, he didn't want to say that he didn't believe the prophets, for that would alienate the Jewish subjects to whose loyalties he wanted to appeal. His non-committal response underlines his discomfort with Paul's testimony.

Acts 26:29

Paul's bold answer shows his quickness in repartee. He challenges Agrippa and his whole audience about the value of knowing Christ and making a personal commitment to him.

Acts 26:31

The consensus of these rulers was that Paul had not done anything to deserve death or imprisonment; this verdict was given repeatedly by the Roman authorities that considered Paul's case (25:25; see [Luke 23:4, 15, 22](#)).

Acts 26:32

He could have been set free: The legal verdict was clear (26:31). But as a practical matter, if he hadn't appealed to Caesar, Paul might not have been alive (25:1–11). As it was, he was fulfilling God's purposes for him (23:11).

Acts 27:1

Julius is otherwise unknown. • The Imperial Regiment (see study note on 10:1–8) served in Syria during this time.

Acts 27:1–28.16

The vivid nautical language used throughout the account of Paul's journey to Rome yields one of the best available accounts of an ancient sea voyage. • This is the last "we" section in Acts (see also [16:10–17](#); [20:5–15](#); [21:1–18](#)). During the two years of Paul's imprisonment, Luke had probably done much of the research for his Gospel throughout Judea and Galilee. Here, as a member of Paul's sailing party, he was an eyewitness participant in the danger at sea.

Acts 27:2

Aristarchus was a native of Thessalonica and a co-worker with Paul in Asia (see [19:29](#); [20:4, 6](#); [Phlm 1:24](#)). • Adramyttium was a port on the west coast of Asia Minor southeast of Troas.

Acts 27:3

Sidon, on the coast about 70 miles (110 km) north of Caesarea, was the first port of call. Julius treated Paul kindly and allowed his local Christian friends to care for him.

Acts 27:4–6

Luke describes in detail the sea voyage north and then west along the southern coast of Asia Minor. • Myra was a regular stop for Egyptian grain ships bound for Italy.

Acts 27:7

The great difficulty was due in part to the lateness of the season (27:9). • Cnidus was a seaport on the southwestern coast of Asia Minor near the island of Cos. • The cape of Salmone was located at the northeastern tip of Crete, the largest of the Greek islands.

Acts 27:8

Fair Havens was a small bay on the southern side of the island of Crete.

Acts 27:9

because it was so late in the fall: This was a dangerous time for a voyage on the Mediterranean.

Acts 27:10–11

Paul realized what would happen if they went on. He warned the ship's officers, but they and the Roman officer were unlikely to listen to an imprisoned Jewish rabbi with no experience as a seaman. Later, however, they would respect him more (27:30–36, 42–43).

Acts 27:12

The prevailing southeasterly winds made Fair Havens an unsafe place for ships to harbor in the winter, but Phoenix, a town farther up the coast of Crete, offered a better harbor.

Acts 27:14–16

The storm, called a "northeaster," was of typhoon strength, very threatening to both the cargo and the crew. Forced to let the ship run before the gale, they sailed past a small island called Cauda (known today as *Gaudos*), south of Crete.

Acts 27:17

- The purpose of wrapping ropes around the ship's framework (hull) was to strengthen it against the storm's pressure. This process is called *frapping*.
- *Syrtis* refers to the shallow bays with *sandbars* off the North African coast, west of Cyrene.

Acts 27:18–20

The violence and persistence of the storm led to throwing the cargo overboard (cp. [Jon 1:5](#)) and the crew's abandoning hope.

Acts 27:21–26

Paul addressed the crew, first scolding them for not listening to him ([27:10–12](#)) and then encouraging them with the angel's assurance of survival for all of them.

Acts 27:27

The Sea of Adria, south of Italy and Greece and between Malta and Crete, is now known as the Ionian Sea.

Acts 27:30–32

This time the soldiers listened to Paul (cp. [27:10–11](#)).

Acts 27:33–35

Paul's words and actions are those of a true leader who personally assesses a perilous situation, decides on action, and leads others in solving the problem (cp. [Neh 1–3](#); contrast [Jon 1](#)). Paul's positive example and strong faith in God ([Acts 27:22–25](#)) encouraged the others to eat and take heart.

Acts 27:36–37

The food brought renewed strength and encouragement to the frightened and exhausted crew and prisoners. • all 276 of us: The exact number of persons onboard fits well with what is known of grain ships of the period.

Acts 27:39–41

They ran the ship aground on a shoal or reef.

Acts 27:42–44

Even in a crisis, the prisoners remained the responsibility of the soldiers (see [12:19](#); [16:27](#); [27:32](#); see study note on [16:27](#)). Fortunately, the commanding officer intervened on their behalf. It was a clear indication of God's protection and favor that all 276 people made it safely to shore, precisely fulfilling the angel's promise (see [27:24](#)).

Acts 28:1

Malta was a major island under Roman control, about sixty miles (100 km) south of Sicily.

Acts 28:3–6

The locals of Malta understood justice as a personified power or deity carrying out judgment on a criminal. When nothing bad happened to Paul, the natives understood him as having power over snakes and concluded that he himself

was a god (cp. [14:11–12](#)). In fact, Paul's survival demonstrated God's protection (cp. [Mark 16:17–18](#)).

Acts 28:8–9

Cp. [Luke 4:38–40](#).

Acts 28:10

Showing their gratefulness, the people supplied the ship's company with what they needed.

Acts 28:11

Another Egyptian ship from Alexandria took Paul and his companions on board after an interval of three months and the worst of the winter had passed.

Acts 28:11–16

Luke, himself present on this journey (see study note on [27:1–28:16](#)), recorded Paul's itinerary from Malta to Rome with great geographical detail.

Acts 28:12

Syracuse was the capital of the eastern half of Sicily.

Acts 28:13–14

They sailed across the Straits of Messina to Rhegium on the southern tip of Italy. This port was a stopping place for ships traveling from the west coast of Italy to the eastern Mediterranean. • Puteoli (modern Pozzuoli) was a major port of entry for large grain ships bringing supplies from the east to Rome. Paul spent a week here with some local believers before moving on to Rome.

Acts 28:15

Paul was greeted by brothers and sisters who met his party on the way up to Rome.

Acts 28:16

Paul was allowed to have his own . . . lodging, apparently in private facilities, though he was guarded by a soldier. Though Paul was traveling in chains, "the word of God cannot be chained" ([2 Tim 2:9](#)). Paul was possibly treated so well because of his social status or Roman citizenship (cp. [Acts 16:37–38](#); [22:25–28](#)).

Acts 28:17–20

Conscious that the Good News was to be presented to the Jews first ([13:46](#); [Rom 1:16](#)) and concerned that the false charges against him might already have reached Rome, Paul summoned the local Jewish leaders and gave an account of his life and work. He insisted that he was guilty of no criminal offense, but strong Jewish opposition had made it

necessary for him to appeal to the emperor. Paul had nothing against his own people; rather, he wanted to explain his great conviction that the Messiah they had been expecting had already come in the person of Jesus of Nazareth.

Acts 28:21–22

The Jewish leaders assured Paul that they had received no reports against him, and they wanted to hear his explanation of this movement.

Acts 28:23

Paul explained how Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament hopes for the Kingdom of God, the master theme of Jesus' own preaching ([Mark 1:14–15](#); see [Matt 4:12–17](#); [Luke 4:14–21, 43](#)). Referring to the Scriptures, Paul presented the case for Jesus as the promised Messiah.

Acts 28:24

Paul's all-day message met a mixed response, as it had in other quarters (e.g., [13:40–51](#); [17:11–14](#)).

Acts 28:25–28

Paul parted with scriptural words of warning that are often used in the New Testament to explain the Jewish rejection of the gospel (cp. [Matt 13:14–15](#); [Mark 4:12](#); [Luke 8:10](#); [John 12:38–40](#); see [Rom 11:1–12, 25–32](#)).

Acts 28:28

Since Jews everywhere had been given an opportunity to accept the faith ([13:46](#); see [Rom 1:16](#)), it was now time for the Gentiles to be offered this salvation.

Acts 28:31

Despite being under house arrest ([28:16](#)), Paul boldly proclaimed the Kingdom message. • And no one tried to stop him (Greek *akōlutōs*, “without hindrance”): This single word in Greek is the last word of the book of Acts and one of the keys to its meaning: God's word cannot be chained, even when its messengers are ([2 Tim 2:9](#); see [Phil 1:12–14](#)). Acts is the story of an unhindered message of Good News, available to all people throughout the world, whether Jew, Gentile, proselyte, rich, or poor. The mission of proclaiming this message is accomplished in the power of the Spirit ([Acts 1:8](#)); it embraces Jews ([3:1–5:42](#)), Samaritans ([8:1–25](#)), converts to Judaism ([2:11](#); [13:43](#)), “God-fearers” ([8:26–40](#); [9:32–11:18](#)), and Gentiles ([13:1–28:28](#)). • Luke ends his account with Paul still under house arrest in Rome (about AD 60–62). Paul was later released and traveled freely. According to tradition, Paul was imprisoned again in Rome about AD 64 and was martyred there during Nero's persecution of believers.